Behind Closed Doors:

Presidential Meetings and Strategic Public Disclosure

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ABSTRACT

The public cannot fully observe what the U.S. president is working on, and the president chooses what to communicate publicly. I examine what drives this strategic disclosure and its capital-market implications. Using Presidential Daily Diaries, I reconstruct the president's minute-by-minute schedule from 1935 through 2009. I use an LLM-assisted process to identify the potential policy topics discussed in each presidential meeting. I apply the same process to identify the topics in the president's public communications. I then measure how closely those communications reflect potential meeting topics. I find that public communications more closely reflect meetings concerning issues voters consider important and less closely reflect meetings concerning politically divisive issues. Specifically, presidents communicate relatively less about issues that divide their own party but relatively more about issues that divide the two parties. When presidential approval is low, public communications shift toward voter priorities and away from within-party divisions. Public communications also more closely reflect meeting topics near Election Day when the incumbent seeks reelection and around funding deadlines that could produce a government shutdown. Greater similarity between presidential meeting topics and public communications is associated with lower subsequent market uncertainty at both the aggregate and firm levels. The uncertainty patterns align with differences in policy exposure and private information access: the association is stronger among firms with greater exposure to government demand and attenuated among firms that meet with the president. Together, these findings are consistent with presidents strategically choose what to reveal about their work and that these disclosures have capital-market implications.

1. INTRODUCTION

Much of what the U.S. president does occurs outside public view. The public instead observes what the President chooses to communicate—including speeches, public remarks, press briefings, and announcements of public travel—as well as information supplied by outside parties, such as media coverage. Accordingly, the topics emphasized in presidential public communications need not reflect what the President is working on. This raises two questions: What drives the President's strategic disclosure of what he is working on, and does that disclosure have capital-market implications?

These questions matter because the President influences regulation, economic policy, and the allocation of public resources. Voters and investors must therefore infer what the President is working on from incomplete information. The President may also have political incentives to publicly discuss some matters but not others. Differences between what the President is working on and what the President communicates may increase policy uncertainty. Prior research links such uncertainty to asset prices and market volatility (Pástor and Veronesi, 2012, 2013; Boutchkova et al., 2012; Brogaard and Detzel, 2015; Kelly, Pástor, and Veronesi, 2016) and to investment and other real decisions (Julio and Yook, 2012; Baker, Bloom, and Davis, 2016; Gulen and Ion, 2016; Hassan et al., 2019). The President's disclosure choices may therefore matter for both political accountability and capital markets.

Voluntary disclosure theory provides a framework for this setting because partial disclosure can survive when receivers do not know whether the sender is informed or when disclosure is costly (Verrecchia, 1983; Dye, 1985). The President, acting through the White House communications apparatus, is the sender. Voters are the primary receivers, but Congress, investors, journalists, firms, and political opponents also use presidential communications (Cohen, 1995;

Kernell, 1997; Canes-Wrone, 2001). The public knows that the President works on many policy matters but generally does not observe his complete set of issue-specific activities on a given day. The presidential setting is also multidimensional. The President chooses how to allocate finite public attention across multiple topics rather than simply whether to reveal a single fact. This resembles voluntary-disclosure settings in which an informed sender selects which subset of multiple signals to disclose (Pae, 2005). Publicizing a topic can benefit the President by demonstrating responsiveness to voter priorities or mobilizing political support. It can also expose divisions within the governing coalition, reduce bargaining flexibility, or enable counteraction by political opponents, as in disclosure models with a strategic opponent (Wagenhofer, 1990). A topic is therefore favorable to disclose when the expected political benefits of publicizing it exceed the associated political and strategic costs.

The primary empirical challenge is measuring what the President is working on. I address this challenge using records from the Presidential Daily Diary. The National Archives and Records Administration (NARA), an independent federal agency, maintains the diary as an official archival record of presidential meetings, telephone calls, and movements. The public cannot access the diary during an administration or for years after a president leaves office. Once released, the diary allows me to reconstruct the President's schedule, including whom the President met with, when each meeting occurred, and how long it lasted. I collect declassified diaries released by the Presidential Libraries in response to FOIA requests for 1935 through 2009. The diaries contain approximately 360,000 activity records covering 168,420 hours and 800,000 meeting-counterparty observations.[2]

[2] The release of the Presidential Daily Diary is regulated by both the Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) and the Presidential Records Act. While the diaries become eligible for FOIA 5 years after a president leaves office, the Presidential Records Act grants the presidents the right to restrict the diaries for up to 12 years. Once the diaries become available for publishing process, the archivists will conduct a line-by-line review for national security sensitive information.

To identify the potential policy topics discussed in each meeting, I implement a prespecified, LLM-assisted process. For each meeting, I record its duration and counterparties. For each counterparty, I use an LLM to classify the person's institutional role and policy work around the meeting date into the 220 detailed topics defined by the Comparative Agendas Project (CAP). This classification estimates the counterparty's policy focus and, in turn, the potential topics of the meeting. Weighting each estimate of counterparty policy focus by meeting duration produces an estimated daily distribution of potential meeting topics.[3] [4]

I use the Presidential Public Papers to identify the policy topics in the President's public communications. The Public Papers contain transcripts of speeches and remarks, formal messages and directives, news conferences, press-secretary briefings, and meeting readouts. I apply the same LLM-assisted process to classify each transcript using the CAP taxonomy. I calculate the cosine similarity between the potential meeting-topic distribution for each day and the public-communication topic distribution for that day and the next six days. Higher values indicate greater similarity between potential meeting topics and public communication topics.[5]

I next develop predictions about the political incentives that affect the President's disclosure choices. First, the President may publicly discuss issues voters consider important and thereby demonstrate an effort to address voters' concerns (Cohen, 1995; Kernell, 1997; Canes-Wrone, 2001a, 2001b). I therefore expect greater similarity when potential meeting topics concern issues voters consider important. However, the opposite prediction is also plausible. The President

[3] For example, I identify legislators' contemporaneous policy focus using their committee assignments and sponsored bills. Because comparable person-level policy-focus measures are not available for all participants, this paper focuses on counterparties in Congress, the executive branch, the judiciary branch, and the White House. Appendix E details the data sources and classification rules.

[4] Recent Studies suggest the robustness and accuracy of this type of LLM-assisted work (e.g., Asirvatham, Mokski, and Shleifer, 2026; Chen, Fang, Zhao, and Zhao, 2024).

[5] Longer 10-, 14-, and 28-day windows are used in untabulated robustness checks

may emphasize popular issues in public communications regardless of whether those issues arise in presidential meetings (Canes-Wrone, Herron, and Shotts, 2001; Maskin and Tirole, 2004).

Second, conflict in Congress may affect what the President communicates publicly. When the President's party controls a chamber, defections within the party can defeat a position that otherwise would have passed. Publicly discussing the issue may draw attention to divisions within the governing coalition. The President may therefore communicate less about issues that expose divisions within his own party (Baum and Groeling, 2010). Alternatively, the President may publicly discuss an issue to pressure members of his party who defect, leading to greater public emphasis on the issue (Kernell, 1997; Canes-Wrone, 2001b). When opposition comes from the other party, however, the President has different incentives. By emphasizing the contested issue, the President can demonstrate an effort to address it, mobilize supporters, and attribute policy failure to the opposition (Groseclose and McCarty, 2001; Noble, 2025). I therefore expect the President to place relatively more public emphasis on issues opposed by the other party. Both forms of conflict may therefore reduce similarity: the President may say less about issues that divide his own party and more about issues opposed by the other party.

I measure these political incentives using information available before the public-communication window and match each measure to the day's distribution of potential meeting topics. Voter Salience measures how important voters consider the day's potential meeting topics based on the latest available Roper Most Important Problem survey. Own-party Conflict measures recent roll calls in which defections within the President's party defeated an otherwise winnable position in a chamber controlled by that party. Inter-party Conflict measures recent organized opposition to the President's party position in a chamber controlled by the other party. It therefore captures opposition that the President can attribute to the other party. I weight both conflict measures by the day's distribution of potential meeting topics.

I find a positive association between Voter Salience and Topic Similarity and negative associations for Own-party Conflict and Inter-party Conflict. These findings suggest that voter priorities and congressional conflict affect how the President communicates what he is working on. The associations are similar across alternative communication windows, measurement horizons, fixed effects, standard-error assumptions, and controls for presidential meetings, public communications, prior topic similarity, and measurement coverage.

I next decompose topic similarity along two dimensions. The first compares the weight of each of 20 broad policy topics (hereafter, "policy areas") in the meeting and communication distributions, distinguishing similar public emphasis, lower public emphasis, omission, and greater public emphasis. The second measures the similarity of potential meeting topics and public communication topics within each policy area. I find that Voter Salience is positively associated with similarity both across and within policy areas. Own-party Conflict is associated with omitting areas from public communications or giving them less weight, whereas Inter-party Conflict is associated with giving disclosed areas more weight. These findings suggest two distinct strategies: silence about internal coalition failure and amplification of external opposition.

I then examine whether these associations vary with presidential approval. When presidential approval is low, the President may have stronger incentives both to address voter priorities and to avoid drawing attention to divisions within his own party. The marginal association between Voter Salience and Topic Similarity increases from 0.039 ($t = 0.72$) when the President's approval rating is at or above its prior median to 0.186 ($t = 3.90$) when it is in the bottom quartile of prior approval ratings. Over the same decline in approval, the marginal association between Own-party Conflict and Topic Similarity decreases from 0.210 ($t = 1.28$) to -0.301 ($t = -2.60$). These findings are consistent with the President communicating relatively more about voter priorities and relatively less about issues that divide his own party when presidential approval is low.

I also examine whether the President's disclosure choices vary around elections. I compare changes in Topic Similarity over the six months before presidential elections in which the incumbent seeks reelection with changes over the same period before midterm elections under the same President. I find a more positive association between proximity to Election Day and Topic Similarity when the incumbent seeks reelection. This pattern suggests that the President's public communications increasingly match what he is working on as Election Day approaches when his own reelection is at stake.

I next examine whether federal budgetary pressure affects presidential disclosure. Funding pressure is not associated with Topic Similarity in the earlier institutional regime. The association becomes positive after the Civiletti Opinion made it more likely that a funding lapse would result in an operational government shutdown. Within the post-Civiletti period, proximity to a funding deadline is positively associated with Topic Similarity, and operational government shutdowns are associated with substantially greater similarity. These findings suggest that the President's public communications more closely match what he is working on when funding disputes can disrupt government operations.

The similarity may capture how informative presidential communication is to investors. Although investors do not observe the later-released Diary, communications that more closely reflect presidential activity may better reveal policy priorities and reduce uncertainty about future policy outcomes (Diamond and Verrecchia, 1991; Easley and O'Hara, 2004; Pástor and Veronesi, 2012, 2013). Therefore, I examine whether Topic Similarity is associated with subsequent capital-market uncertainty. At the aggregate level, greater similarity is associated with lower abnormal market volatility following the public-communication window, lower realized market variance, and lower cross-industry return dispersion. I find no similar associations during pre-communication placebo windows. At the firm level, greater similarity is associated with lower Fama–French three-factor idiosyncratic volatility and lower standardized excess-return uncertainty over the same post-communication horizon.

I next conduct two tests of this negative uncertainty association. First, I examine whether the association varies with Political Exposure, measured as an industry's direct and indirect exposure to government demand. The interaction between Topic Similarity and Political Exposure is negative for industry-portfolio volatility, firm-level idiosyncratic volatility, and within-industry dispersion. Second, I examine whether the association changes after firms obtain private presidential access. In a stacked design comparing meeting firms with future-treated firms that meet the same president later, the negative association between Topic Similarity and idiosyncratic volatility attenuates in the post-meeting period.

These findings are consistent with investors learning from public communications that more closely represent what the President is working on and with private access substituting for information conveyed by the public signal. They do not, however, establish that more similar communication causally reduces market uncertainty. Topic Similarity is not randomly assigned and may covary with unobserved features of presidential meeting topics or the political environment. Political Exposure is also not randomly assigned and may proxy for other industry characteristics associated with return uncertainty. Although the private-access design compares meeting firms with future-treated firms that have not yet met the same President, private access and meeting timing remain endogenous. The private-meeting estimates therefore identify changes in the Topic Similarity slope rather than the direct causal effect of either private presidential access or more similar public communication on volatility.

The paper makes three contributions. First, I connect two related strands of research on the presidency: the "going public" literature on presidential communication and the literature on presidential time allocation and political access. In the going-public literature, Kernell (1997) studies presidents' use of public appeals to build support for their policies, while Baum and Kernell (1999) examine how the expansion of cable television affected presidents' ability to reach a national audience. The time-allocation and political-access literature instead studies how presidents work and the consequences of access to policymakers. Beckmann (2024) studies the heterogeneity of working styles across presidents. Brown and Huang (2020) examine the operational consequences of executives visiting White House during the Obama administration. Using similar diary records, Drechsel (2026) identifies presidential interactions with Federal Reserve officials and examines the consequences of political pressure on monetary policy. I connect the two by comparing the topics of presidential meetings with the topics of public communications. This comparison reveals a previously unobserved communication choice: how selectively the President communicates what he is working on. I find that presidents communicate less about work that imposes costs on their own coalition, communicate more about work that imposes costs on the opposition, and align public communication more closely with their activities on issues that voters value. I therefore characterize presidential communication as a strategic choice about whether and how to communicate what the President is working on.

Second, I contribute to the voluntary disclosure and proprietary-cost literature in a political setting. Canonical models examine whether and when an informed manager reveals information when disclosure is costly (Verrecchia, 1983; Dye, 1985; Verrecchia and Weber, 2006; Guttman, Kremer, and Skrzypacz, 2014). However, researchers generally cannot assess how closely disclosure represents what an informed agent knows because they cannot observe the informed agent's information set. Research on segment reporting provides early evidence and finds that managers aggregate economically distinct operations to protect proprietary information and, in some settings, to make activities that reflect poorly on management less visible (Botosan and Stanford, 2005; Bens, Berger, and Monahan, 2011). The presidential setting allows me to observe both what the President is doing and what he communicates publicly. I therefore extend the voluntary disclosure and proprietary-cost literature by measuring disclosure relative to an observable activity benchmark and showing how political benefits and costs shape whether and how an informed political actor communicates what he is working on.

Third, I contribute to the literature on political uncertainty and asset pricing. Prior research measures political uncertainty using political events, news coverage, asset prices, or firms' discussions of political risk (Pástor and Veronesi, 2012, 2013; Boutchkova et al., 2012; Baker, Bloom, and Davis, 2016; Kelly, Pástor, and Veronesi, 2016; Hassan et al., 2019). I extend the political-uncertainty literature from measuring and pricing uncertainty to studying the supply of political information by the policymaker and the conditions under which that public signal appears most informative.

The remainder of this paper is organized as follows. Section 2 introduces the institutional background. Section 3 discusses the theories and develops hypotheses. Section 4 describes the data, variable construction, and research design. Sections 5 and 6 present the results, and Section 7 concludes.

2. INSTITUTIONAL BACKGROUND

Two institutional processes generate the records used in this study. The first records the President's activities for administrative and archival purposes. The second produces public communications intended for contemporaneous audiences. These processes differ in purpose, production, and release timing. The Presidential Daily Diary records presidential meetings, calls, and movements, but it does not become publicly available until years later. Whereas presidential public communications enter the public information set when released. This institutional separation allows me to compare a later-released record of presidential activity with what the White House communicated publicly at the time.

2.1 Archival Record of Private Presidential Activities

The Presidential Daily Diary is produced through an internal White House recordkeeping process. The information used to compile the Diary comes from appointment calendars, schedules, telephone records, transportation records, participant lists, and reports supplied by White House units. Appendix A presents examples from the Presidential Daily Diary of President George H. W. Bush and President Richard Nixon. The example identifies the time and location of each activity, the nature and duration of the activity, and the names and titles of the participants.

The procedures used to compile the Diary have changed over time. Earlier administrations relied on appointment calendars, schedules, White House ushers, stenographers, and presidential secretaries. Beginning with the Nixon Administration, a NARA employee detailed to the White House generally served as the Presidential Diarist. The diarist compiles information supplied by different White House units into a chronological record of the President's activities. The diarist typically remains in the position across multiple administrations, insulating the record-keeping process from partisan influence. This arrangement provides continuity in recordkeeping across administrations.

The archival record of the Presidential Daily Diary is not produced for contemporaneous public disclosure, and remains strictly exempt from public access requests via the Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) for the first five years after a president leaves office. Furthermore, the Presidential Records Act (PRA) grants outgoing presidents the statutory authority to invoke specific restriction categories that can shield these records for up to twelve years. Once these statutory restrictions expire and the diary becomes subject to the FOIA process, the diary undergoes an archival processing by NARA to redact classified material, such as national security sensitive information. After this processing, the diary may be released through the relevant Presidential Library.

This institutional delay is critical to the design. On a meeting date, the public could not observe the complete presidential activities used in this study. The paper is in the position of an ex post observer where the archival record is used to estimate the presidential meeting topics and to examine how similar the public communication topics correspond to the private meeting topics.

2.2 Public Presidential Communication

Unlike the Presidential Daily Diary, presidential public communications are produced for contemporaneous release. Some communications are delivered directly by the President. Others are prepared or disseminated by the Press Office, other White House staff, or federal agencies on the President's behalf. Together, these communications form the public record of what the White House communicates about the President's activities and policy priorities.

The textual records of these public presidential communications are compiled by the Office of the Federal Register (OFR) and the National Archives and Records Administration (NARA). These materials are subsequently bound into the semi-annual *Public Papers of the Presidents of the United States*. The official series was established in 1957 and includes retrospective volumes for President Herbert Hoover. The Public Papers organize the communications chronologically and provide a standardized historical record across administrations.

2.3 Implications for Measurement

Three institutional features affect the interpretation of the measures used in this study. First, a Diary entry records the occurrence of an activity rather than the substantive content of the underlying conversation. I therefore infer the potential policy topics of a meeting from the institutional roles and contemporaneous policy work of the counterparties. I refer to these classifications as potential meeting topics because the Diary does not reveal what the participants actually discussed.

Second, the coverage and documentary style of the Presidential Daily Diary vary across administrations. The empirical specifications include president-year-month fixed effects and controls for measurement coverage, but these procedures cannot eliminate all differences in recordkeeping.

Third, the Public Papers contain communications produced through different institutional processes. White House staff and federal agencies may contribute to the preparation of these materials. I therefore interpret the resulting measure as public presidential communication and do not assume that the President personally prepared every document.

Taken together, these features define the interpretation of the similarity measure used in this study. It measures how closely the potential topics of presidential meetings correspond to the topics in presidential public communications. It does not directly measure whether the public communications reproduce the exact content of the underlying conversations.

3. THEORIES AND HYPOTHESIS DEVELOPMENT

3.1 Strategic Presidential Disclosure

Voluntary disclosure theory suggests that an informed agent need not reveal all private information when disclosure is costly (Verrecchia, 1983; Dye, 1985; Verrecchia, 2001; Guttman, Kremer, and Skrzypacz, 2014). In classic models, the agent's disclosure choice reflects a trade-off between the benefits of informing outside audiences and the costs imposed by revealing information.

This theory motivates the paper's framework of presidential disclosure. On each date, the President works on different policy topics and decides how to allocate public communication across those topics over the following days. He weighs the benefits of discussing each topic against the political costs of doing so. Because the President typically works on multiple topics and public attention is scarce, increasing the relative prominence of one topic reduces the prominence of others. Selective disclosure can therefore reduce how closely the topics that the president is working on to the topics in presidential public communications.

Voting and the constitutional system of checks and balances provide a useful lens for understanding how these benefits and costs affect presidential disclosure. Voters and Congress impose different constraints on the President's disclosure choices (Wehner and de Renzio, 2013). I conceptualize voters and congress as relevant stakeholders of the presidential disclosure and analyze how they are associated with the presidential disclosure decisions.

3.2 Voter Salience and Benefits of Public Responsiveness

Voter Salience can increase the political return to public responsiveness. Voters cannot continuously observe the President's activities, but they can update their beliefs using presidential public communications. When presidential meeting topics concern issues that voters already consider important, communicating about those same topics allows the President to demonstrate responsiveness and claim credit for addressing public concerns. This logic is consistent with evidence that presidential rhetoric and public issue salience move together and with theories in which presidents use public appeals when mobilizing public opinion can advance their policy objectives (Cohen, 1995; Kernell, 1997; Canes-Wrone, 2001a, 2001b).

This prediction is not without tension. The President can also use public communications to redirect public attention toward preferred policy topics. If agenda setting dominates responsiveness, Voter Salience may lead the President to amplify a small number of issues rather than align public communications with his meeting topics. Moreover, communicating about an issue voters consider important may be unattractive when the administration has made little policy progress.

3.3 Own-party Coalition and Defensive Concealment

Presidential disclosure also affects the bargaining environment. Transparency can improve accountability, but it can also harden positions, expose disagreement, and make compromise more costly (Stasavage, 2004). When members of the President's party disagree over a policy topic, publicly discussing the topic can reveal coalition fragility, weaken the President's bargaining position, and reduce the President's claim to govern effectively. The administration may therefore protect the coalition by placing less public emphasis on the topic.

A countervailing mechanism suggests that going public can be used to discipline legislators, raise the electoral cost of defection, or build support for the president's position. A sufficiently popular president may therefore expose internal disagreement rather than conceal it.

The defensive-concealment prediction is most likely to hold when public communication is more likely to advertise failure than to change legislators' incentives and when the President's political standing is weak.

3.4 Inter-party Resistance and Offensive Amplification

Inter-party Conflict creates a different disclosure problem. Classic closed-door bargaining models imply that publicity can reduce the opportunity for compromise (Stasavage, 2004). However, an identifiable opposition also provides the President with a target for assigning responsibility. In models of public appeals and blame allocation, the President can publicly discuss contested issues to demonstrate effort, mobilize public pressure, and shift responsibility for inaction to political opponents (Canes-Wrone, 2001b; Groseclose and McCarty, 2001). Amplification is then valuable because it makes the external constraint visible.

Taking voter salience and congressional conflict together, I propose the following nondirectional hypothesis,

Hypothesis 1: Level of similarity is associated with voter salience, own-party coalition, and inter-party resistance.

3.5 Presidential Disclosure and Uncertainty

Political information affects asset prices when investors are uncertain about future policy and its distributional consequences (Pástor and Veronesi, 2012, 2013; Boutchkova et al., 2012; Brogaard and Detzel, 2015; Kelly, Pástor, and Veronesi, 2016). A more informative public signal can reduce one component of that uncertainty by helping investors infer which policy topics the President is working on. Disclosure theory also posits more informative public information to lower information asymmetry and a less adverse trading environment (Diamond and Verrecchia, 1991; Easley and O'Hara, 2004).

In the presidential setting, investors observe presidential public communications and use these signals to update their beliefs about future regulatory, procurement, enforcement, and legislative outcomes. When presidential public communication is less aligned with topics that the president is working on, investors receive a less informative signal about future policy state. Accordingly, I expect lower similarity to weaken the information environment and increase return volatility. Therefore, I propose the following hypothesis,

Hypothesis 2: Greater similarity is associated with lower capital market uncertainty following the disclosure.

4. DATA, MEASUREMENT, AND RESEARCH DESIGN

4.1 Presidential Daily Diary and Potential Meeting Topics

The construction of the potential meeting-topic distribution begins with 584,970 presidential activity records collected from official diaries and schedules. The records span January 4, 1935, through January 20, 2009. I retain activity categories that plausibly reflect what the President is working on, including briefings, meetings and telephone calls, document and legislative work, nominations, diplomacy, travel and inspections, meals, and specified individual work. I exclude ceremonial, family, and location-only activities.[6] I also require a named counterparty for interactions used to estimate potential policy topics

[6] Appendix A lists all the presidential activity types in the unexcluded data.

Appendix Table F.1 reports the sample construction. Removing ceremonial, family, and location-only activities eliminates 244,713 records, and requiring a counterparty eliminates an additional 38,661 records. I then exclude observations with missing time information, unusually large group events, insufficient identifying information, or counterparties outside the White House, executive branch, legislative branch, and judiciary. The resulting analytic file contains 226,349 presidential activities, 332,725 meeting-counterparty observations, and 88,795 recorded hours.[7]

The unit used to construct the daily distribution is a meeting-counterparty observation. I weight each counterparty's policy portfolio by the activity duration divided by the number of retained counterparties participating in the activity. An activity with several retained counterparties therefore contributes several duration-per-person-weighted policy portfolios whose weights sum to the activity's duration. This construction measures the time-weighted policy composition of presidential activities rather than giving each meeting equal weight.

4.2 Estimating Counterparty Policy Portfolios

A diary entry rarely identifies the specific policy topics discussed. I estimate the potential topics of each meeting using the institutional role and contemporaneous policy activities of each counterparty. I map all inputs into the Comparative Agendas Project (CAP) taxonomy, which contains 20 policy areas and 220 detailed policy topics.[8] Appendix D presents the taxonomy. I limit the analysis to presidential activities involving counterparties from the White House, executive branch, legislative branch, and judiciary because comparable historical policy-portfolio records

[7] Meeting length is bounded between one and 480 minutes to limit the influence of coding errors and day-long schedule blocks

[8] I combine immigration and culture within the same area structure while retaining detailed topics to ensure each area has at least two detailed topics for mathematic computation.

are unavailable for other types of counterparties. Appendix C reports the included and excluded counterparty types.

The inputs used to estimate a counterparty's policy portfolio depend on the person's institutional role and policy activities. I generally combine a static description of the counterparty's institutional responsibilities with dynamic records of policy activities around the meeting date. When only one type of input is available, I use that input alone.

Specifically, for White House counterparties, I use annual agency or position descriptions from the U.S. Government Manual or the White House Transition Project. For executive-branch counterparties, I combine annual agency or position descriptions from the U.S. Government Manual with proposed rules published by the affiliated agency in the Federal Register during the 90-day period beginning on the meeting date. For congressional counterparties, I combine committee assignments with bills sponsored or introduced during the 90-day period beginning on the meeting date. For judicial counterparties, I use opinions filed during the 365-day period beginning on the meeting date. When both static and dynamic inputs are available, I assign equal weight to the two inputs.

I use forward-looking policy activities because the objective is to estimate potential meeting topics rather than to reconstruct the information available to outside observers on the meeting date. Proposed rules, introduced bills, and filed opinions generally result from agenda setting, drafting, negotiation, or deliberation that begins before the formal action enters the public record. An activity recorded after a meeting can therefore reveal policy work already underway at the time of the meeting, whereas an activity completed before the meeting may concern a matter no longer under consideration. The forward-looking construction is thus an ex post measurement choice; it does not treat future policy activities as part of the contemporaneous public information set.

However, forward-looking inputs might be biased when a future policy activity reflects a new policy development that is neither in the counterparty's true policy portfolio at the meeting time, nor initiated by the presidential meeting. In the untabulated robustness tests, I use only the static description of the counterparty's institutional responsibilities to estimate a counterparty's policy portfolio, the results are robust[9].

I use a large language model (LLM) to map the static and dynamic textual inputs into the 220 detailed policy topics. I use the Gemini 3.1 Pro model with temperature set to zero. Recent studies provide evidence on the validity of LLM-assisted classification and measurement (e.g., Asirvatham, Mokski, and Shleifer, 2026; Chen, Fang, Zhao, and Zhao, 2024). Appendix G presents a representative prompt. For each input type, I manually review a random sample of the LLM outputs. Roll-call votes and congressional committee assignments do not require LLM classification because Wilkerson et al. (2025) provide the relevant topic classifications.

For president-day d, let $z_{m,j}$ be the 220-topic portfolio of counterparty j in activity m, and let l_m be the duration of that activity. The potential meeting topic distribution is $P_d = \frac{\sum_m \sum_j l_m z_{m,j}}{\sum_m \sum_j l_m}$, where the sums run over retained meeting-counterparty rows on date d

4.3 Constructing the Public Disclosure Signal

The Presidential Public Paper contains 59,975 textual presidential communication documents dated from March 4, 1933 through January 19, 2017. It includes addresses, news

[9] A post review suggests that dynamic records of policy activities around the meeting date contributes about 15% mass when estimating the counterparty's policy portfolio.

conferences, exchanges with reporters, remarks, statements, messages to Congress, bill-signing and veto messages, proclamations, executive orders, memoranda, diplomatic records, correspondence, and institutional releases. The public communication estimation excludes personnel actions and domestic ceremonial records, which generally do not convey a policy topic, and retains the other classified document types.

I assign each retained document a 220-topic vector using the same LLM-assisted classification process. I normalize each document vector to sum to one and give each document equal weight. In an untabulated robustness test, I instead weight documents by word count.

For each private activity date d, the public signal $Q_{d,7}$ aggregates retained documents dated d through d + 6. Seven calendar days allow a meeting topic to appear in scheduled remarks or releases without attributing communication weeks later to the original meeting. 10-, 14-, and 28-day windows are used as untabulated horizon sensitivity robustness check. A day enters the main analysis only if both a potential meeting topic distribution and at least one retained public document are available.

4.4 Measures of Topic Similarity

The primary outcome is cosine similarity between the potential meeting topic distribution and public communication topic distribution:

$$\text{Topic Similarity}_d = \frac{P_d \cdot Q_{d,7}}{||P_d||\ ||Q_{d,7}||}$$

The measure equals zero when the two nonnegative distributions have disjoint support and one when they are proportional. It captures the alignment of the full 220-topic composition and is invariant to the number or length of public documents after each distribution is normalized[10]. This invariance is useful for measuring similarity, but it also means that the measure is not a volume-of-disclosure outcome.

4.5 Political Incentives and Costs

Voter Salience measures the overlap between the meeting policy area share and the latest Roper Most Important Problem distribution whose fieldwork ended strictly before the activity date. If several usable studies end on the same date, their policy vectors are equally weighted; the most recent survey-date vector is then carried forward until a newer survey becomes available. The regressions control for the share of survey responses successfully mapped into the policy taxonomy and the age of the survey.

Own-party Conflict and Inter-party Conflict are built from roll calls strictly before the activity date. For each party, chamber, and policy area, I calculate exact rolling histories over the prior 24 months. *Own-party Conflict* uses votes in a chamber controlled by the president's party. It equals twice the share of counted own-party dissent multiplied by an indicator that the party's modal position lost but would have won had counted dissenters joined that position. *Inter-party Conflict* uses a chamber not controlled by the president's party. It equals $\max\{0, 2r - 1\}$, where r is opposing-party resistance to the focal party's counted modal position, and is positive only when the focal party's position lost and could not have prevailed even after all eligible own-party members were placed on its modal side. The two active chambers receive equal potential weight. A channel active in only one chamber therefore contributes at half scale; an institutionally inactive

[10] An alternative similarity measurement is constructed using the 20-Broad Topic composition. The main results are robust to this measure (untabulated).

channel is coded as zero. Daily measures weight policy area cost by the potential meeting area share[11].

4.6 Baseline specification and inference

The baseline daily specification regresses the Presidential *Topic Similarity* on *Voter Salience*, *Own-party Conflict,* and *Inter-party Conflict*. It absorbs president-year-month and weekday fixed effects and clusters standard errors by president-year[12]. Controls include the mapped share and age of the MIP survey; the log number and total minutes of private activities; meeting-topic concentration and its square; the log number of public documents and the number of communication days in the disclosure window; backward-looking similarity over the preceding seven days; and coverage measures for the two roll-call constructs. Continuous unbounded variables are winsorized at the 1st and 99th percentiles.

The fixed effects compare days within a president-month, holding constant persistent presidential style and common monthly shocks. They do not supply random assignment. Voter priorities, legislative frictions, and presidential communication can respond to common events; coefficients are therefore interpreted as conditional associations consistent with the proposed disclosure incentives.

4.7 Descriptive Statistics

The determinant sample begins in 1947, when the political-cost and personal policy portfolio inputs support the complete specification, and ends on January 14, 2009 so the full seven-

[11] The three incentive measures are mapped to the private meeting using the 20-policy areas by CAP, because the provided classifications of the survey responses and the congressional roll calls are at the Broad Topic level.

[12] HAC standard errors with a bandwidth of 7 days are used as untabulated robustness due to the autocorrelation concern. All the results in the paper are robust to the HAC SE.

day communication window remains within the administration. Table 1 reports 15,871 complete president-days before one absorbed fixed-effect singleton is removed from the baseline regression. Mean Topic Similarity is 0.0765, with a median of 0.0386. The low level is expected for a 220-topic high-dimensional similarity calculation.

5. POLITICAL DETERMINANTS OF POLICY TOPIC SIMILARITY

5.1 Voter Salience and Political Costs

Table 2 presents the baseline daily estimates. *Voter Salience* is positively associated with *Topic Similarity*. In the full specification, the coefficient is 0.1696 (t = 7.09). A one-standard-deviation increase in *Voter Salience* corresponds to a 0.0094 increase in *Topic Similarity*, or approximately 0.093 standard deviations of the outcome. Both political-cost coefficients are negative. The coefficient on *Own-party Conflict* is −0.1802 (t = −2.12), and the coefficient on *Inter-party Conflict* is −0.1187 (t = −2.69). At the sample standard deviations, the implied changes are −0.0078 and −0.0192, respectively, equivalent to 0.077 and 0.191 standard deviations of the similarity[13].

5.2 Policy Area Allocation and Within-area Similarity

To better understand the different margins in the presidential disclosure decisions, I decompose overall *Topic Similarity*. Let $P_{d,a}$ and $Q_{d,a}$ denote the meeting-area and communication-area shares for area (broad topic) a. *Relative Area Emphasis* is $1 - \left|\frac{(Q_{d,a} - P_{d,a})}{(Q_{d,a} + P_{d,a})}\right|$. *Area Under-*

[13] Inter-party Conflict remains robust if a 12-month specification is used. However, Own-party Conflict becomes statistically indistinguishable from zero in the 12-month model, likely due to reduction in variation.

emphasis is $\max\{\frac{(P_{d,a} - Q_{d,a})}{(Q_{d,a} + P_{d,a})}, 0\}$; *Area Over-emphasis* is $\max\{\frac{(Q_{d,a} - P_{d,a})}{(Q_{d,a} + P_{d,a})}, 0\}$; and *Area Omission* equals one when $P_{d,a}$ is positive but $Q_{d,a}$ equals zero. A conditional over-emphasis specification is estimated only among areas with positive public communication share. The main area regressions require a meeting-area share at least 0.1 percent and include President-Date and President-Area fixed effects.

Within each area that has positive meeting-area and communication-area weight and at least two meeting-topics, I renormalize the topic distribution vectors and calculate the Bhattacharyya, or Hellinger, affinity. Higher values indicate greater within-area similarity. Hellinger affinity is used due to the renormalization process. I also report within-area cosine similarity.

Tables 3 and 4 separate the margins that generate the daily Topic Similarity result. The unit in Table 3 is a president-date-area observation. President-date fixed effects absorb every daily factor shared across the 20 areas, including the level of overall communication; president-area fixed effects absorb persistent differences in how a president treats an area. The estimates thus ask which areas of the potential meeting-topic receive disproportionate communication weight on the same day.

Voter Salience increases *Relative Area Emphasis* by 0.0897 (t = 3.64). It reduces *Area Under-emphasis* by 0.2040 (t = −4.46) and *Area Omission* by 0.1486 (t = −3.60). The unconditional *Area Over-emphasis* component is positive, but the coefficient falls to 0.0401 (t = 1.50) when the sample is conditioned on positive communication weight. Taken together, the results indicate that voter salience mainly moves important topics into the public communication and protects them from being under-disclosed.

Own-party Conflict operates through the defensive margin predicted in hypothesis development. Its coefficient on *Area Omission* is 0.1326 (t = 2.77). The coefficient on *Relative Area Emphasis* is negative but not statistically significant. The results thus indicate when the president's party has recently suffered coalition on an area, the area is more likely to disappear from the subsequent public communication.

Inter-party Conflict exhibits the opposite margin. It raises conditional over-emphasis by 0.0881 (t = 2.87), while its omission and under-emphasis coefficients are not significant. This evidence supports the blame-allocation rather than the closed-door concealment alternative. Opposition resistance reduces overall cosine similarity because the affected area or topic is amplified beyond its private meeting share.

Table 4 asks whether political incentives and costs also change the detailed topic similarity within am area (broad topic). Conditional on positive meeting-area and communication-area weight and at least two potential meeting-topic, *Voter Salience* raises the Hellinger affinity by 0.0855 (t = 2.21) and the cosine similarity by 0.0736 (t = 1.75). The own-party and inter-party conflicts are not significantly related to either measure. The main cost results therefore arise from the allocation of public communication across policy areas (broad topics), whereas voter salience also carries some information about the similarity within an area.

5.3 Presidential Approval

The returns to the disclosure strategies should vary with political stakes. High disapproval increases the implied value of demonstrating responsiveness to voters and the cost of exposing a weak governing coalition. It can therefore strengthen both the positive association between voter salience and similarity and the negative association between own-party conflict and similarity.

I define presidential disapproval relative to each president's own prior history. Disapproval rate is calculated as disapproval share among respondents expressing an approval or disapproval opinion. The Presidential Disapproval equals zero if the approval rate at or above the president's prior median, one below the median but outside the prior bottom quartile, and two within the prior bottom quartile. The preferred interaction specification restricts survey age to fourteen days and controls continuously for that freshness.

Table 5 presents the results. The most informative estimates arise when survey age is limited to fourteen days. In that sample, the three interaction terms are jointly significant ($p < 0.001$). The *Voter Salience* interaction is 0.0733 ($t = 2.03$), and the *Own-party Conflict* interaction is −0.2557 ($t = -2.78$); the *Inter-party Conflict* interaction is small and insignificant.

The marginal slopes make the interaction concrete. At or above a president's prior median standing, the *Voter Salience* slope is 0.039 ($t = 0.72$) and the *Own-party Conflict* slope is 0.210 ($t = 1.28$). At the intermediate disapproval state, the corresponding slopes are 0.112 ($t = 3.13$) and −0.046 ($t = -0.42$). In the president's prior bottom quartile, they are 0.186 ($t = 3.90$) and −0.301 ($t = -2.60$). The association between *Inter-party Conflict* and *Topic Similarity* remains negative at all three states and does not vary significantly with disapproval. Freshness matters for interpretation. Without a maximum survey-age restriction, the interaction block is not significant ($p = 0.341$). The approval evidence is therefore consistent with the predicted responsiveness and coalition-protection channels.

5.4 Reelection Incentives

Personal reelection incentives provide an additional source of institutional variation. As Election Day approaches, an incumbent who is actively seeking another term internalizes more directly the electoral return from the public communication than a president at the same point in a midterm cycle[14]. This comparison predicts a rising level of similarity when the incumbent is a candidate. Whether the three incentive slopes also change is a less general prediction because campaigns may compress communication around a small set of electorally useful issues.

The design follows the six months preceding Election Day, includes election-event and relative-election-month fixed effects, and clusters by election event. Truman in 1952 and Johnson in 1968 change status after their public withdrawals.

Table 6 shows the results. The interaction between incumbent-candidate status and proximity to Election Day is 0.0676 (t = 4.68); in the fully interacted specification it is 0.0991 (t = 2.31). The sample contains 2,028 president-days, 16 election events, and eight presidents. Using all same-president midterms as benchmarks yields coefficients of 0.0373 (t = 2.99) and 0.1135 (t = 4.15). These estimates support that *Topic Similarity* rises more sharply toward Election Day when the president's own continuation in office is at stake.

The channel interactions are less stable. In the immediately preceding-midterm design, the three candidate-by-proximity-by-incentive terms are jointly significant (p = 0.015), but only the inter-party interaction is individually significant at conventional levels. In the all-midterm design, the Own-party and Inter-party interactions are negative and the joint p-value is 0.002.

5.5 Funding Pressure and Shutdown

Federal funding deadlines create a setting in which institutional constraint becomes unusually visible. A lapse in appropriations does not necessarily produce the same operational consequences in every historical period. The April 1980 and January 1981 opinions of Attorney

[14] In an untabulated test, I examine an alternative design that a president who is ineligible for an additional presidential term is compared to his prior presidential election. I am unable to document any significant results, potentially due to a power issue that only 4 presidents are in the sample.

General Benjamin Civiletti articulated a more restrictive application of the Anti-deficiency Act during a funding lapse, subject to limited exceptions. The January 16, 1981 opinion provides a useful boundary for the modern enforcement regime in which funding failures can require agencies to suspend nonexcepted operations (Office of Legal Counsel, 1980, 1981; U.S. General Accounting Office, 1981).

The topic similarity can increase with the funding pressure. Approaching deadlines concentrate spotlights on a known institutional process, and operational disruption makes the link between private bargaining and public consequences harder to obscure. The president may respond by revealing his private meeting more faithfully or by using the public record to assign responsibility. A competing bargaining account predicts the opposite, sensitive negotiations and the risk of public posturing can increase the value of silence.

I define Funding Pressure as a linear index that rises from zero to one during the final fourteen days before the governing funding deadline and remains one during a funding gap. Alternative windows range from seven to thirty days[15]. The historical comparison separates dates before January 16, 1981 from the modern shutdown-enforcement regime beginning with the Civiletti opinion.

Table 7 tabulates the results. Across the full historical sample, *Funding Pressure* has no significant pooled association with *Topic Similarity*. The interaction between the pressure and the modern shutdown-enforcement regime is 0.0366 ($t = 2.07$), and the implied post-1981 slope is 0.0251 ($p = 0.060$).

In the realized-episode specification, an operational shutdown is associated with a 0.0942 increase in *Topic Similarity* ($t = 2.54$), whereas a modern funding gap without operational

[15] The timing evidence is concentrated near deadlines. The implied modern-regime slope is most precisely estimated in seven- and fourteen-day pressure windows and weakens as the window expands toward thirty days.

shutdown has a small, insignificant coefficient. When shutdown is interacted with the baseline incentives, the shutdown main effect becomes imprecise and the shutdown-by-Inter-party Conflict coefficient is 0.6158 ($t = 4.37$); the shutdown interaction block is jointly significant ($p = 0.001$).

The evidence suggests that funding pressure is associated with greater Topic Similarity only in the regime in which a lapse can trigger visible operational consequences, and the sharpest increase occurs during actual shutdowns. This pattern is consistent with enforceable visibility changing the return to public explanation and blame allocation.

6. TOPIC SIMILARITY AND UNCERTAINTY

The market tests ask whether the topic similarity is associated with the subsequent information environment. For each presidential activity date, I identify the final date of any public communication released during the following seven calendar days and measure market uncertainty over the next five trading days. Tables 8–10 estimate the average relation between Topic Similarity and aggregate and firm-level uncertainty. Tables 11 and 12 examine whether this relation varies with government-demand exposure and after private presidential access.

6.1 Aggregate Uncertainty

The aggregate outcomes are abnormal market volatility from a GJR-GARCH model, realized market variance, and cross-sectional return dispersion across the 48 Fama–French industries. The controls include matched pre-period outcomes, market returns, the volume and concentration of presidential meetings and communication events, backward similarity, the political-incentive variables, and the meeting shares of 19 policy areas, with Public Lands omitted. Standard errors use a 28-day Bartlett heteroskedasticity-and-autocorrelation correction.

Table 8 reports that greater similarity is associated with lower uncertainty following the communication window. In the full specification, the coefficient on *Topic Similarity* is −0.1371 (t = −3.08) for post-period abnormal market volatility, −0.2640 (t = −2.96) for realized market variance, and −0.0448 (t = −3.05) for post-period industry return dispersion.

Table 9 replaces the post outcome with two pre-communication windows. *Topic Similarity* is not significantly related to abnormal volatility in the recent pre-period (coefficient −0.0606, t = −1.40) or in the earlier pre-period (coefficient 0.0015, t = 0.08). Stricter timing variants yield the same qualitative conclusion. These nulls reduce the concern that the post coefficient merely reflects a stable tendency for presidents to disclose more similar on generally calm dates. They do not fully rule out shocks that occur during the communication window and jointly determine both similarity and subsequent volatility.

6.2 Firm-level Uncertainty

Table 10 extends the analysis to firm-day outcomes. Excess-return uncertainty is the log root-mean-square of standardized excess returns over the five post-communication trading days; the standardization uses the firm's prior 252 trading days, requires at least 126 observations, and excludes the current date. Idiosyncratic volatility is constructed analogously from residuals of a Fama–French three-factor model estimated only with prior returns. The regressions include president-by-firm, final-communication year-month, weekday, and last communication lag from the activity date fixed effects; exact macro controls; and the firm's pre-period uncertainty. Each presidential meeting date receives total weight one, and standard errors are clustered by firm and presidential activity date.

The sample contains approximately 58.8 million firm-day observations and 22,245 firms. Topic Similarity is negatively associated with both outcomes: the coefficient is −0.0359 (t = −4.54) for excess-return uncertainty and −0.0295 (t = −5.01) for idiosyncratic volatility.

6.3 Political Exposure and Uncertainty

I next examine whether the negative association between Topic Similarity and return uncertainty varies with firms' exposure to government demand. Public communication that more closely represents what the President is working on may resolve more uncertainty when presidential policy bears more directly on expected cash flows. Accordingly, the negative association should be stronger for firms and industries with greater exposure to government demand. This prediction implies a negative coefficient on the interaction between Topic Similarity and Political Exposure. The sign is not mechanical, however, because more similar communication could instead make unresolved policy risk more salient for government-dependent firms.

Following Belo, Gala, and Li (2013), I construct Political Exposure from the BEA benchmark input-output accounts. Political Exposure is the total output required from an industry to satisfy federal, state, and local government final demand, divided by the industry's total output. The numerator includes both output sold directly to government final demand and output required indirectly through input-output linkages. I assign each benchmark vintage to July–June formation years based on when the benchmark information became publicly available. The main analysis retains these public-release vintages and excludes formation years 1992 and 1993, for which the unavailable 1982 SIC-to-I-O concordance would require a proxy. I map firms to three-digit SIC industries before 2003 and to the most detailed matched NAICS prefix from 2003 onward. Political Exposure is standardized within each formation year, across matched firms in the firm-level regression and across represented industries in the industry-level regressions.

I estimate a cross-sectional extension of the firm-uncertainty specification that includes Topic Similarity, Political Exposure, and their interaction. Because Political Exposure is standardized within formation year, the interaction coefficient measures the change in the Topic Similarity slope associated with a one-standard-deviation increase in exposure. The firm specification uses firm-level idiosyncratic volatility. The first industry specification uses the idiosyncratic volatility of a June-fixed, equal-weighted industry portfolio. The second measures within-industry dispersion by calculating the cross-sectional standard deviation of firm-level Fama–French residuals on each trading day and then taking the log root mean square of those daily standard deviations over the five-day outcome window. Industry-date observations require at least five firms. The sample runs from July 1, 1955 through January 14, 2009 and contains 13,502 presidential activity dates. It includes 49,916,901 firm–activity-date observations covering 21,567 firms and approximately 2.02 million industry–activity-date observations covering 461 industries.

Table 11 reports negative interaction coefficients in all three columns. For industry-portfolio volatility, the coefficient is −0.0092 (t = −2.03). For firm-level idiosyncratic volatility, the coefficient is −0.0089 (t = −3.71). For within-industry dispersion, the coefficient is −0.0058 (t = −1.76). Thus, a one-standard-deviation increase in Political Exposure makes the Topic Similarity slope more negative by 0.0092, 0.0089, and 0.0058, respectively. The pattern is consistent with more similar communication resolving more uncertainty when presidential policy is more relevant to firm cash flows. The within-industry result provides evidence that the association also extends to heterogeneous firm-level responses within exposed industries.

6.4 Private Presidential Access and Uncertainty

I next use private presidential access to examine whether the negative association between Topic Similarity and firm-level uncertainty changes when a firm has an alternative information channel. A private meeting may give firm representatives information about what the President is working on that is not otherwise available through public communications. If public communications are less incremental after such access, the negative association should become weaker for the meeting firm.

Table 12 implements a stacked difference-in-differences-in-differences design around private-sector presidential meetings involving at least one top-ranked firm representative. Column (1) defines treatment as the firm's first meeting with a given President. Column (2) includes all eligible first and repeated meetings between the firm and that President. The controls are history-aligned, future-treated firms. A control firm is associated with the same President, has no prior meeting with that President as of the focal meeting date, and is confirmed to have its first meeting with that President in the future. This design compares firms at different points in their same-President meeting histories rather than comparing meeting firms with firms that never obtain presidential access.

For each private access date, I construct Topic Similarity using the presidential activity on that date and the public documents released over the following seven calendar days. Idiosyncratic Volatility is measured over the five trading days beginning after the final public communication in the corresponding package. The short-post DDD coefficient is the treated-versus-control Topic Similarity slope in the short-post period minus its calendar-width-weighted clean-pre average. The later-post DDD coefficient is defined analogously.

The first-meeting specification contains 551 treated firm-meeting episodes across 456 President–date stacks. The all-meetings specification contains 1,001 treated episodes across 806 stacks. Table 12 reports a short-post DDD coefficient of 0.3398 (t = 2.27) for first meetings and 0.2258 (t = 1.84) for all meetings. These positive coefficients suggest that the treated-control difference in the Topic Similarity slope shifts upward after private access. They are consistent with the negative association between Topic Similarity and idiosyncratic volatility becoming weaker for meeting firms.

The corresponding pre-trend estimates are −0.1027 (t = −0.75) and 0.0343 (t = 0.33). The absence of a significant difference between the late and early clean pre-periods reduces the concern that the post-meeting estimates continue a differential preexisting change in the Topic Similarity slope.

Taken together, Tables 8–10 support H2 as an association: public communications that more closely represent what the President is working on are followed by lower uncertainty at both the aggregate and firm levels. Table 11 shows that this negative association is more pronounced among firms and industries with greater exposure to government demand, consistent with the public signal being especially informative when presidential policy is more directly relevant to firm cash flows. Table 12 provides complementary evidence consistent with substitution: the negative association between Topic Similarity and firm-level uncertainty becomes weaker after firms obtain private presidential access. These patterns are consistent with information resolution of uncertainty.

Several alternative interpretations remain. A president may communicate more faithfully when the administration itself faces less uncertainty; staff may produce clearer documents after policy choices have been resolved; or omitted events may improve both policy clarity and market conditions. Overlapping seven-day windows also cause a public communication to contribute to more than one meeting date. The political exposure test is subject to an additional limitation. Political Exposure is not randomly assigned and may capture persistent or time-varying industry characteristics related to both policy sensitivity and return uncertainty. The negative interaction therefore does not establish that government exposure causally amplifies the effect of presidential disclosure. The private-access design remains subject to additional limitations. The timing and participants of presidential meetings are not randomly assigned, and firms may obtain access when their policy exposure, information environment, or expected uncertainty is changing. The future-treated controls and clean-pre comparisons align firms on their meeting histories, but they do not eliminate selection into access. The joint support rule also conditions the sample on usable observations in both the short- and later-post periods. Accordingly, the private access test does not estimate the direct causal effect of a presidential meeting on volatility, the direct effect of public disclosure, or a change in the level of firm uncertainty caused by the meeting.

Taken together, the market analyses should therefore be presented as evidence that the measured Topic Similarity contains information about uncertainty, not as an estimate of the causal effect of truthful political disclosure on volatility.

7. CONCLUSION

This paper studies a disclosure choice that is ordinarily untouched: how the U.S. president publicly discloses what he is working on. By mapping archival presidential meeting records and public presidential communication into the same policy topic taxonomy, the paper constructs a daily measure of meeting-communication similarity.

The results are consistent with presidents strategically disclosing in economically and institutionally meaningful ways. A potential meeting topic aligned with voter priorities is communicated with higher similarity. Political difficulty within the president's party is associated with omission and under-emphasis, whereas resistance from the opposition is associated with over-emphasis. Approval and election tests suggest that political vulnerability and personal electoral stakes condition these choices. Funding pressure operates principally in the modern shutdown-enforcement regime and is most visible during operational shutdowns.

The similarity measure is also associated with the subsequent market information environment. Higher meeting-communication similarity is followed by lower aggregate abnormal volatility, realized variance, industry dispersion, excess-return uncertainty, and idiosyncratic volatility.

The negative association is stronger among firms and industries with greater Political Exposure, measured as direct and indirect exposure to government demand. It becomes weaker following private meetings involving top-ranked firm representatives. These patterns are consistent with the topic similarity being informative about market uncertainty, and with the public communication resolving more uncertainty where government demand matters more for cash flows and private information access substitute the public signals.

The paper's central contribution is connecting what the president is doing to what the president is communicating, establishing a framework where disclosure theories can provide a better understanding of presidential communication decisions. The results are consistent with presidents strategically disclose the distribution of policy issues in response to political incentives.

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Appendix A. Examples of Presidential Daily Diary

THE WHITE HOUSE

THE DAILY DIARY OF PRESIDENT GEORGE BUSH Page 1

LOCATION: THE WHITE HOUSE
WASHINGTON, D.C.

DATE: SEPTEMBER 27, 1991

TIME: 5:30 a.m. DAY: FRIDAY

IN	OUT	PHONE	ACTIVITY
5:30			The President had coffee with: Barbara Bush, The First Lady Jonathan J. "Johnny" Bush, the President's brother Mrs. Jonathan J. "Johnny" (Josephine "Jody") Bush, the President's sister-in-law
6:54			The President went to the South Grounds of the White House.
6:55			The President went to the Oval Office.
7:00	7:15		The President met with his Assistant for National Security Affairs, Brent Scowcroft.
7:10	7:12	R	The President talked with Robert A. Teeter, President, Coldwater Corporation, Ann Arbor, Michigan.
			The President met with:
7:15	7:32?		Mr. Teeter
7:17	7:32		John H. Sununu, Chief of Staff
7:15	7:56		Mr. Scowcroft
7:16	7:23	P	The President talked on a secure conference line with: Francois Mitterrand, President of the Republic of France Cornelius F. O'Leary, Director, White House Situation Room, National Security Council (NSC) Barry F. Lowenkron, Director, European and Soviet Affairs, National Security Council (NSC) Carol Wolter, interpreter, Department of State
7:49	7:56	P	The President talked on a secure conference line with: John Major, Prime Minister of the United Kingdom of Great Britian and Northern Ireland (UK) Mr. O'Leary Mr. Lowenkron

Note: A Part of President George Bush's Diary on the Morning of Sept 27, 1991

THE WHITE HOUSE

PRESIDENT RICHARD NIXON'S DAILY DIARY
(See Travel Record for Travel Activity)

P

PLACE DAY BEGAN: THE WHITE HOUSE, WASHINGTON, D.C.

DATE (Mo., Day, Yr.): JUNE 21, 1972

TIME: 8:50 a.m. DAY: WEDNESDAY

TIME In	TIME Out	PHONE (P=Placed R=Received) Lo	PHONE LD	ACTIVITY
8:50				The President had breakfast.
9:05				The President went to the Oval Office.
9:10			P	The President telephoned long distance to Mayor Louie Welch (D-Houston, Texas) in New Orleans, Louisiana. The call was not completed.
9:23	9:25		P	The President talked long distance with Mayor Welch in New Orleans, Louisiana.
				The President met with:
9:30	10:38			H. R. Haldeman, Assistant
10:12	10:16			Alexander P. Butterfield, Deputy Assistant
10:13	10:38			Charles W. Colson, Special Counsel
10:22		P		The President telephoned Congressman John J. Rooney (D-New York). The call was not completed.
				The President met to discuss the state of the economy with the Quadriad:
10:40	12:30			George P. Shultz, Secretary of the Treasury
10:40	12:30			Arthur F. Burns, Chairman of the Board of Governors of the Federal Reserve System
10:40	11:56			Caspar W. Weinberger, Director of the OMB
10:40	11:56			Herbert Stein, Chairman of the Council of Economic Advisers (CEA)
12:10	12:12			Mr. Butterfield
12:25	12:26			Mr. Butterfield
				Members of the press, in/out
				White House photographer, in/out
10:44	10:45	P		The President talked with Congressman Rooney.
12:04			R	The President was telephoned long distance by his daughter, Julie, in Mayport, Florida. The call was not completed.
12:28	12:29	P		The President talked with Deputy Director of the CIA Maj. Gen. Vernon A. Walters.
12:33	12:34		R	The President talked long distance with his daughter, Julie, in Mayport, Florida.
				The President met to announce the approval of an urban mass transit grant for New York City with:
12:38	1:08			Governor Nelson A. Rockefeller (R-New York)
12:38	1:10			John A. Volpe, Secretary of Transportation
12:38	1:08			Senator Jacob K. Javits (R-New York)
12:38	1:08			Senator James L. Buckley (Conservative-New York)
12:38	1:22			John D. Ehrlichman, Assistant

Note: A Part of President Richard Nixon's Diary on June 21, 1972 (The Watergate scandal was first reported on Jun 20.)

THE WHITE HOUSE

PRESIDENT RICHARD NIXON'S DAILY DIARY
(See Travel Record for Travel Activity)

A

PLACE DAY BEGAN

THE WHITE HOUSE
WASHINGTON, D.C.

DATE (Mo., Day, Yr.)
JUNE 22, 1972

TIME: 9:02 a.m. DAY: THURSDAY

TIME		PHONE P=Placed R=Received		ACTIVITY
In	Out	Lo	LD	
9:02				The President had breakfast.
9:20				The President went to his office in the EOB.
				The President met with:
9:40	11:25			H. R. Haldeman, Assistant
10:20	10:21			Gordon C. Strachan, Staff Assistant
11:10	11:11			Bruce A. Kehrli, Staff Secretary
9:45	9:50	P		The President talked with his Press Secretary, Ronald L. Ziegler.
11:29	11:39	P		The President talked with his Special Counsel, Charles W. Colson.
12:14	12:15	P		The President talked with Constance Stuart, Staff Director for the First Lady.
12:56	1:08	P		The President talked with Mr. Ziegler.
1:35	1:45			The President met with Mr. Ziegler.
2:30	2:35			The President met with his Deputy Assistant, Alexander P. Butterfield.
2:58				The President went to Mr. Butterfield's office.
2:58	3:00			The President met with Mr. Butterfield.
3:00				The President went to his private office.
3:00	3:02			The President met with Mr. Butterfield.
3:03				The President went to the Oval Office.
3:03	3:44			The President held a press conference on domestic issues with members of the press. For a list of attendees, see APPENDIX "A."
				The President met with:
3:44	4:04			Mr. Haldeman
3:44	4:04			Mr. Ziegler
4:03	4:06			Mr. Butterfield
4:06	4:35			The President met to receive a report on the financial crisis of Catholic schools in Philadelphia and surrounding counties with: John Cardinal Krol, Archbishop of Philadelphia and President of the American Council of Catholic Bishops

Note: A Part of President Richard Nixon's Diary on June 22, 1972 (The Watergate scandal was first reported on Jun 20.)

Appendix B. Types of Presidential Activities

This table presents the taxonomy used to classify presidential activities. The first column reports activity categories used to group related activity types. The second column reports the presidential activity types. U.S. refers to the United States. The Classification is accomplished by LLM (Gemini-3.1-Pro) combining manual audit.

Category	Activity Type
Presidential Work, Governance, and Policy Execution	National Security Meetings and Briefings
	Non-National Security Meetings with Counterparty
	Bill or Document Signing, Approvals, and Issuance
	Nomination Events
	Work Alone
Diplomatic and Foreign Affairs Activities	Diplomatic & Foreign Relation Events in the U.S.
	Diplomatic & Foreign Visits International
Public Communication, Media, and Political Activities	Campaign Activities
	Photo Opportunities
	Audio and Video Taping Opportunities
	Media Interviews, Press Conferences and Briefings
	Public Speeches, Remarks, and Addresses
Movement, Travel, and Location Status	Domestic Travel & Transit outside the White House
	Domestic Tour or Inspection of Location or Facility
	Movement within the White House
	Location Status
Ceremonial, Social, and Representational Activities	Greetings, Welcomes, Receptions, Receiving Lines, Farewell, and Handshake
	Ceremonial activities
	Attending Performance or Entertainment
	Dining and Banquets
	Religious Services
Private, Personal, Family, and Health Activities	Wake Up, Retiring and Sleeping
	Family Activities
	Recreation and sports activities
	Medical, Health, and Personal Care

Appendix C. Types of Counterparties in the Presidential Meetings

This table reports the counterparty type taxonomy used to classify individuals meeting with the president. Each row corresponds to one parent counterparty category. The second column lists the counterparty subtypes included under each parent type. EOP refers to the Executive Office of the President; U.S. refers to the United States; DOJ refers to the Department of Justice. The Classification is accomplished by LLM (Gemini-3.1-Pro) combining manual audit.

Category	Counterparty Type
White House and EOP Internal	Gatekeeping and coordination; policy staff; political, public liaison, and intergovernmental affairs; communications, press, and speechwriting; national security staff; legislative affairs; counsel and legal; appointments, scheduling, and personnel; Vice President and Office of the Vice President; First Lady and First Family official role; EOP statutory office head; White House and EOP operations staff; others
U.S. Executive Branch and Agency	Cabinet secretary; deputy, undersecretary, or assistant secretary; independent agency chair or commissioner; administrator, bureau chief, or component head; senior regulator or enforcement head; military or intelligence official; DOJ leadership, federal prosecutor, or investigative head; U.S. ambassador, diplomat, or foreign-service official; federal advisory board or commission member; career civil servant or technical expert; others
U.S. Congress	House leadership; Senate leadership; House committee chair or ranking member; Senate committee chair or ranking member; House subcommittee chair or ranking member; Senate subcommittee chair or ranking member; House member, delegate, or resident commissioner; senator; personal office staff; leadership staff; committee staff; congressional officer or support agency official; others
U.S. Judiciary	Supreme Court justice; federal appellate judge; federal district judge; other federal judge or judicial official; state supreme court justice or chief justice; state judge or court official; judicial administration or court governance official; others
State, Local, Tribal, and Territorial Government	Governor; lieutenant governor or statewide executive official; mayor; county executive or county official; state legislator; city manager or county administrator; local agency head; school district head; special district or authority head; state attorney general, state prosecutor, or legal officer; tribal government leader; territorial government official; regional or metropolitan authority official; others
Private Sector	Public-firm CEO or chair; private-firm CEO, chair, or owner; other senior corporate executive; banker, broker-dealer, insurer, or asset manager; private equity, venture capital, hedge fund, or other investor; founder, entrepreneur, or controlling shareholder; small business owner; farmer, rancher, or producer; government contractor or defense contractor executive; others

Industry and Business Organization	Trade association head; chamber of commerce head; industry coalition or employer federation head; sector representative delegation; state or local chamber or sector council; professional business association leader; economic development or business civic leader; others
Labor	National union leader; sector union leader; public-sector union leader; labor federation or central labor council leader; worker or rank-and-file labor delegation; strike committee or bargaining delegation; others
Civil Society, Nonprofit, Education, Religion, and Science	Advocacy group leader; civil-rights organization leader; religious or denominational leader; nonprofit service-organization leader; foundation or philanthropy leader; think tank or policy institute leader; academic or scientist; professional or learned-society leader; outside expert, commission member, or advisory-panel expert; university or college president or administrator; education-sector leader; medical or public-health expert; cultural institution leader; veterans organization leader; community organization or local civic leader; others
Media	Journalist, correspondent, or columnist; broadcaster, anchor, or commentator; publisher or editor; media executive, station manager, or network executive; media owner or proprietor; photographer, photojournalist, or newsreel operator; others
Foreign Official, Diplomatic, and International Organization	Head of state or government; foreign minister or senior cabinet minister; ambassador, chargé, or senior diplomat; special envoy or negotiator; international organization official; royal family or sovereign when relevant; foreign military or intelligence official; foreign legislative leader or parliamentarian; foreign party or opposition leader; foreign central banker or economic official; foreign subnational official; foreign official delegation member not otherwise classified; others
Campaign, Party, and Electoral	National party chair or party committee officer; congressional campaign committee leadership; state party chair or committee officer; donor, fundraiser, bundler, finance chair, or host; campaign manager or senior campaign staff; political consultant, strategist, pollster, media adviser, or legal operative; candidate for office or campaign principal; party activist or precinct organization leader; others
Personal, Family, and Social	Family member or First Family in personal capacity; personal friend or social acquaintance; personal attorney or personal adviser; household, residence, or personal staff; social guest or private guest; personal service provider; others
Public, Symbolic, and Cultural	Individual citizen or private citizen; student, youth, or child visitor; veteran, military family, or Gold Star family; athlete or sports figure; artist, entertainer, or cultural figure; award recipient or honoree; public delegation or visitor group; ceremonial or commemorative representative; disaster victim, affected resident, or beneficiary; others
Professional Services and Intermediaries	Lobbyist or government relations professional; lawyer or law firm partner; accountant, auditor, or professional services executive; consultant or public affairs adviser; broker, fixer, or political intermediary; association management or representation professional; public relations or communications firm professional; policy consultant or technical contractor; others

Unclear or Insufficient Information	Unidentified named person; unidentified title only or no institutional role; other unclassifiable

Appendix D. Comparative Agendas Project (CAP) Policy Topics

This table reports the CAP policy topic taxonomy used to classify the latent presidential agenda and the presidential disclosure. The first column reports the CAP major topic label, and the second column reports the corresponding CAP subtopic label.

CAP Major Topic	Included CAP Subtopics
Macroeconomics	General; Interest Rates; Unemployment Rate; Monetary Policy; National Budget; Tax Code; Industrial Policy; Price Control; Other
Civil Rights	General; Minority Discrimination; Gender Discrimination; Age Discrimination; Handicap Discrimination; Voting Rights; Freedom of Speech; Right to Privacy; Anti-Government; Other
Health	General; Health Care Reform; Insurance; Drug Industry; Medical Facilities; Insurance Providers; Medical Liability; Manpower; Disease Prevention; Infants and Children; Mental Health; Long-term Care; Drug Coverage and Cost; Tobacco Abuse; Drug and Alcohol Abuse; R&D; Other
Agriculture	General; Trade; Subsidies to Farmers; Food Inspection & Safety; Food Marketing & Promotion; Animal and Crop Disease; Fisheries & Fishing; R&D; Other
Labor	General; Worker Safety; Employment Training; Employee Benefits; Labor Unions; Fair Labor Standards; Youth Employment; Migrant and Seasonal; Other
Education	General; Higher; Elementary & Secondary; Underprivileged; Vocational; Special; Excellence; R&D; Other
Environment	General; Drinking Water; Waste Disposal; Hazardous Waste; Air Pollution; Recycling; Indoor Hazards; Species & Forest; Land and Water Conservation; R&D; Other
Energy	General; Nuclear; Electricity; Natural Gas & Oil; Coal; Alternative & Renewable; Conservation; R&D; Other
Immigration and Culture	General Immigration; General Culture

Transportation	General; Mass; Highways; Air Travel; Railroad Travel; Maritime; Infrastructure; R&D; Other
Law and Crime	General; Agencies; White Collar Crime; Illegal Drugs; Court Administration; Prisons; Juvenile Crime; Child Abuse; Family Issues; Criminal & Civil Code; Crime Control; Police; Other
Social Welfare	General; Low-Income Assistance; Elderly Assistance; Disabled Assistance; Volunteer Associations; Child Care; Other
Housing	General; Community Development; Urban Development; Rural Housing; Rural Development; Low-Income Assistance; Veterans; Elderly; Homeless; R&D; Other
Domestic Commerce	General; Banking; Securities & Commodities; Consumer Finance; Insurance Regulation; Bankruptcy; Corporate Management; Small Businesses; Copyrights and Patents; Disaster Relief; Tourism; Consumer Safety; Sports Regulation; R&D; Other
Defense	General; Alliances; Intelligence; Readiness; Nuclear Arms; Military Aid; Personnel Issues; Procurement; Installations & Land; Reserve Forces; Hazardous Waste; Civil; Civilian Personnel; Contractors; Foreign Operations; Claims against Military; R&D; Other
Technology	General; Space; Commercial Use of Space; Science Transfer; Telecommunications; Broadcast; Weather Forecasting; Computers; R&D; Other
Foreign Trade	General; Trade Agreements; Exports; Private Investments; Competitiveness; Tariff & Imports; Exchange Rates; Other
International Affairs	General; Foreign Aid; Resources Exploitation; Developing Countries; International Finance; Western Europe; Specific Country; Human Rights; Organizations; Terrorism; Diplomats; Other
Government Operations	General; Intergovernmental Relations; Bureaucracy; Postal Service; Employees; Appointments; Currency; Procurement & Contractors; Property Management; Tax Administration; Scandals; Branch Relations; Political Campaigns; Census & Statistics; Capital City; Claims against the government; National Holidays; Other
Public Lands	General; National Parks; Indigenous Affairs; Public Lands; Water Resources; Dependencies & Territories; Other

Appendix E. Crosswalk from Counterparty Identity to Personal CAP Focus

This table summarizes the data sources and procedures used to estimate counterparties' policy protfolio. Each row reports a data source used for a given counterparty parent type, the role of that source in assigning CAP focus, and the frequency at which the source is observed or updated. Daily sources are used to capture short-window changes in policy portfolios, whereas annual sources are used to identify institutional roles, office jurisdictions, and relatively stable policy portfolios. Counterparties classified as Media; Campaign, Party, and Electoral; Personal, Family, and Social; Public, Symbolic, and Cultural; Professional Services and Intermediaries; and Unclear or Insufficient Information are excluded because data inavailibility. CAP refers to the Comparative Agendas Project; EOP refers to the Executive Office of the President; U.S. refers to the United States.

Counterparty Category	Data Source	Data Description	Procedures
White House and EOP Internal	U.S. Government Manual	Annual summary of governmental agencies and their senior officials' activity	1. Use LLM to calculate a role's (agency's) static weighted CAP focus based on summary. 2. Assign weighted CAP focus to a counterparty's roles (if the role is identified in the manual). 3. Assign weighted CAP focus to a counterparty's belonging agency (if the role is not identified in the manual nor the WHTP)
	White House Transition Project Records	Annual summary of White House officials' job description	4. Use LLM to calculate an official's static weighted CAP focus based on job description. 5. Assign weighted CAP focus to a counterparty (if a counterparty is identified in the WHTP, but not identified in the manual).
U.S. Executive Branch and Agency	Federal Register Rules and Regulations	Daily publication of proposed rules, final rules, and regulatory activities by all executive agencies	1. Use LLM to calculate dynamic weighted CAP focus using proposed rules in the 90 days beginning on the meeting date.
	U.S. Government Manual	Annual summary of governmental agencies and their senior officials' activity	2. Use LLM to calculate a role's (agency's) static CAP focus based on summary. 3. Assign 50% dynamic CAP + 50% static CAP to a counterparty.
U.S. Congress	Personal Legislative Activities	Daily record of legislative activities by all congressional members (e.g., bill sponsorship, introduction, debate and voting, etc.)	1. Use LLM to calculate dynamic weighted CAP focus using proposed bill in the 90 days beginning on the meeting date.
	Congressional Committee Roles	Annual summary of individual congressional committee assignment	2. Assign static CAP focus based on the member's congressional committee role. 3. Assign 50% dynamic CAP + 50% static CAP to a counterparty.

U.S. Judiciary	Judicial opinions and cases	Daily record of judicial activities by judges	1. Use LLM to calculate dynamic weighted CAP focus using issued opinions in the 365 days beginning on the meeting date. 2. Assign the dynamic CAP to a counterparty.

Appendix F. Selection of Private Presidential Activities

	Total Presidential Activities	Total Counterparties	Total Hours
Presidential Daily Diary	584, 970		
Less: Ceremonial, family, and location events	(244,713)		
Less: No counterparty mentioned	(38,661)		
	301,596	594,555	
Less: Missing time information	(11,618)	(34,549)	
	289,978	560,006	137,808
Less: Large Group Events	(5,531)	(107,375)	(7,139)
Less: Insufficient identity information	(1,330)	(2,221)	(577)
Less: Counterparties not from White House or Constitutional Branches	(56,768)	(117,685)	(41,297)
Sample used to construct estimated potential meeting topics	**226,349**	**332,725**	**88,795**

Appendix G. Distribution of Private Presidential Activities by Presidents

	Total Presidential Activities	Total Counterparties	Total Hours
Franklin D. Roosevelt (Democrat)	12,710	18,473	12,057
Harry S. Truman (Democrat)	9,598	14,270	4,640
Dwight D. Eisenhower (Republican)	16,551	27,992	6,574
John F. Kennedy (Democrat)	4,712	10,733	2,005
Lyndon B. Johnson (Democrat)	43,644	58,281	14,010
Richard Nixon (Republican)	33,150	37,692	11,711
Gerald Ford (Republican)	11,768	16,111	5,577
Jimmy Carter (Democrat)	18,423	26,315	7,976
Ronald Reagan (Republican)	17,640	31,741	5,952
George H.W. Bush (Republican)	23,923	30,152	6,033
Bill Clinton (Democrat)	26,230	45,741	10,511
George W. Bush (Republican)	8,000	15,224	1,749
Total	**226,349**	**332,725**	**88,795**

Appendix H. A Representative Prompt to Transform the Textual Inputs to the 220-topic Portfolio

You are a deterministic research-data coder. Your task is to infer the substantive policy focus of one historical record and map that focus to the supplied Comparative Agendas Project (CAP) taxonomy.

NON-NEGOTIABLE MEASUREMENT RULES
1. Use only CAP codes that appear verbatim in CAP_TAXONOMY. Never invent, shorten, lengthen, or translate a code. Use the exact code printed in the taxonomy. Prefer the most specific code supported by the evidence.
2. Base the classification on the supplied source content and source-specific context. External or model-internal historical knowledge is prohibited unless ALLOW_EXTERNAL_KNOWLEDGE=true. When it is allowed and used, identify that fact explicitly.
3. Separate observed extraction from inferred policy focus. Do not treat a person's title, an agency name, a court's procedural language, or a document format as sufficient evidence of substantive policy focus unless the source-specific rules below permit it.
4. If the record lacks enough evidence for a defensible CAP classification, return classification_status="insufficient_evidence" and an empty cap_topics array. Do not guess.
5. For a coded record, CAP weights must be nonnegative, and must sum to exactly 1.000000 after rounding to six decimals. Weight by substantive attention in the available evidence, not by the number of labels mentioned.

SOURCE-TYPE ROUTING
A. public_paper_text_or_xml
- Read the full available document in sequence.
- Build a short sequential_topic_map before aggregating CAP weights.
- Use the document's substantive discussion; do not code ceremonial or format language as policy content.

B. federal_register_compact_record
- Treat title, subject, action, summary, agency, date, and document type as separate evidence fields.
- Give priority to title/subject/action/summary. Agency identity alone may corroborate but may not determine a topic.
- If only a generic agency/title is available, return insufficient_evidence rather than reconstructing the document from memory.

C. government_manual_pdf_or_xml
- First extract the official agency, sub-agency, officer, role, mission/role description, and source location (page or XML path).
- Assign agency focus from explicit mission/responsibility text.
- Assign officer focus from explicit role/purview text. Only if specific purview is absent may the officer inherit the parent agency vector; then set inherited_parent_focus=true.
- For XML, ignore blank-name leadership rows and section headers; preserve explicit vacancies.

D. whtp_with_description
- Read the focal chart and baseline Description.pdf together.
- Preserve the chart hierarchy and exact office/title text.
- Use Description.pdf role descriptions as the first basis for officer focus. Use parent-office inheritance only when specific purview is absent and flag it.

E. judicial_opinion
- Classify the underlying substantive public-policy domain, not litigation procedure or the mere fact of adjudication.
- Do not use courts/procedure, crime, or civil-rights topics unless they are themselves the substantive issue.
- If the dispute is purely personal/private law with no broader regulatory, economic, governmental, or institutional domain, return classification_status="skipped_private_law" and an empty cap_topics array.
- If the opinion text is truncated, classify only the available text and metadata and set input_truncated=true.

Appendix I. Variable Definitions

Variable	Definition
A. Presidential meeting and disclosure measures	
Topic Similarity	Cosine similarity between the potential meeting-topic distribution on date t and the public-communication topic distribution of the communication events issued from t through t+6. The measure ranges from zero to one.
Backward Topic Similarity	Cosine similarity between the potential meeting-topic distribution on date t and the public-communication topic distribution of the communication events issued from t-7 through t-1. The measure ranges from zero to one.
Relative Area Emphasis	For policy area a, $1 - \lvert (Q_a - P_a)/(Q_a + P_a) \rvert$, where P_a is the area a's share in the potential meeting-topics on t and Q_a is the area a's share in the public-communication topic from t through t+6. It equals one at exact correspondence and approaches zero as the shares diverge. The sample requires $P_a \geq 0.001$.
Area Under-emphasis	For policy area a, $\max\{(P_a - Q_a)/(P_a + Q_a), 0\}$. P_a is on date t, and Q_a is from t through t+6.
Area Omission	Indicator equal to one when policy area is identified the potential meeting-topic distribution on t but no public communication from t through t+6 (Q_a=0), and zero otherwise. P_a is on date t, and Q_a is from t through t+6.
Area Over-emphasis	For policy area a, $\max\{(Q_a - P_a)/(P_a + Q_a), 0\}$. P_a is on date t, and Q_a is from t through t+6.
Backward Area Under-emphasis	For policy area a, $\max\{(P_a - Q_a)/(P_a + Q_a), 0\}$. P_a is on date t, and Q_a is from t-7 through t-1.
Backward Area Omission	Indicator equal to one when policy area is identified the potential meeting-topic distribution on t but no public communication from t through t+6 (Q_a=0), and zero otherwise. P_a is on date t, and Q_a is from t-7 through t-1.
Backward Area Over-emphasis	For policy area a, $\max\{(Q_a - P_a)/(P_a + Q_a), 0\}$. P_a is on date t, and Q_a is from t-7 through t-1.
Within-Area Hellinger Affinity	Bhattacharyya coefficient, $\Sigma_k \sqrt{(p_k q_k)}$, between the two policy topic distributions of a policy area, renormalized within policy area a. It ranges from zero to one. The measure requires positive topic shares in the both distributions and at least two positive topics with area.
Within-Area Similarity	Cosine similarity between the two policy topic distributions of a policy area after each is renormalized within area a.
-ΔArea Share	For policy area a, the measure is calculated as Q'_a - Q_a. Q'_a is from t-7 through t-1; and Q_a is from t through t+6.
Has Prior Communicated	An Indicator variable equal to 1 if a policy area was communicated from t-7 through t-1.

Variable	Definition
B. Political incentives and institutional conditions	
Voter Salience	Dot product of the potential meeting-area distribution on t and the latest available prior distribution of voter responses to the Most Important Problem question.
Voter Salience_Area	Latest available prior Most Important Problem share mapped to policy area a.
Own-party Conflict	A potential meeting-area-weighted exposure to internal-party conflict over the preceding 24 calendar months. Within an active chamber controlled by the president's party, the score is twice own-party dissent multiplied by an indicator that the party's modal side lost but would have won had dissenters joined it. Active House and Senate scores are equally weighted.
Inter-party Conflict	A potential meeting-area-weighted exposure to organized opposition over the preceding 24 calendar months. In a chamber not controlled by the president's party, the score is max{0, 2×opposing-party resistance to the focal party's modal position−1}. Active House and Senate scores are equally weighted.
Own-party Conflict Coverage	Share of the potential meeting-area for which the Own-party Conflict measure has usable roll-call history.
Inter-party Conflict Coverage	Share of the potential meeting-area for which the Inter-party Conflict measure has usable roll-call history.
Disapproval	Ordinal political-vulnerability state based on the latest approval survey that strictly predates t: zero when opinionated approval is at or above the president's own prior median; one when it is below the median but at or above the prior 25th percentile; and two when it is below the prior 25th percentile. Opinionated approval equals approval/(approval+disapproval) and requires at least five prior survey events.
Election Proximity	Linear time index over the six months before Election Day, equal to zero at the start of the window and one on Election Day.
Presidential Candidate	Indicator equal to one when the sitting president is actively pursuing another presidential term, and zero for midterms and presidential succession elections in which the incumbent is not running. Truman in 1952 and Johnson in 1968 switch to zero after their public withdrawal dates.
Funding Pressure	Fourteen-day governing-deadline pressure index. It equals zero more than 14 days before the funding deadline and 1−days-to-deadline/14 during the final 14 days.
Post-Civiletti Opinion	Indicator for the modern operational-shutdown enforcement regime beginning January 16, 1981.
Funding Pressure × Post-Civiletti Opinion	Product of Funding Pressure and Post-Civiletti Opinion.
Shutdown	Indicator equal to one during a modern-regime funding gap that produces an operational federal-government shutdown.
Funding Gap without Shutdown	Indicator equal to one during a modern-regime lapse in funding that does not produce an operational shutdown.
C.communication, and survey controls	
Ln(Number of Meetings + 1)	Natural logarithm of one plus the number of unique private presidential activity records contributing to potential meeting-topic distribution on t.

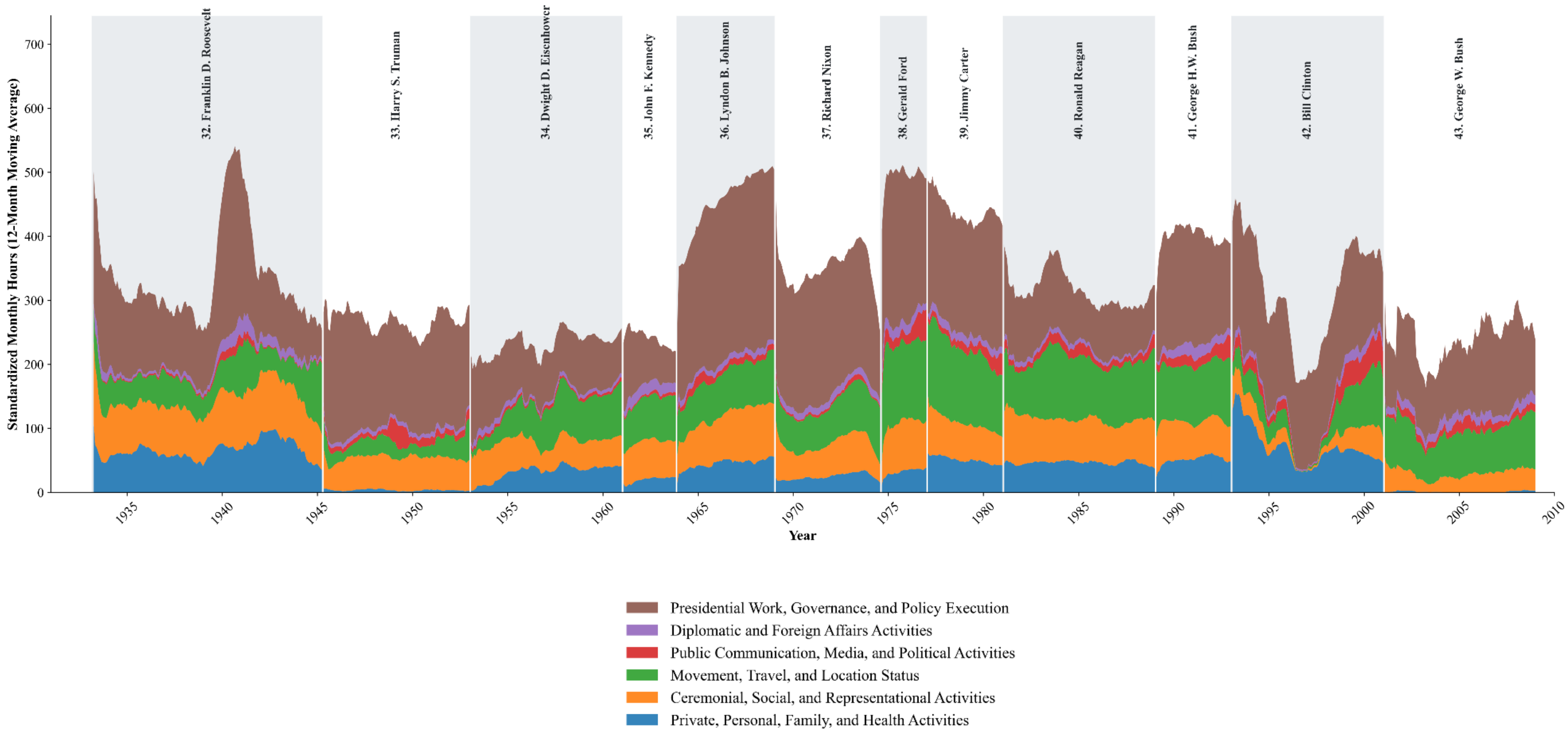
Variable	Definition
Ln(Meeting Length + 1)	Natural logarithm of one plus total minutes in the private presidential activity records contributing to potential meeting-topic distribution on t.
Topic Concentration	Herfindahl–Hirschman index of the potential meeting-topic distribution on t.
Topic Concentration²	Square of Topic Concentration.
Area Share	Share of meeting-topics on t assigned to policy area a.
Area Share²	Square of *Area Share*.
Within-area Topic Concentration	Herfindahl–Hirschman index of potential meeting-topic shares after the distribution is renormalized within policy area a.
Within-area Topic Concentration²	Square of *Within-area Topic Concentration*.
Ln(Number of Communication Events + 1)	Natural logarithm of one plus the number of retained Public Papers documents issued from t through t+6.
Number of Communication Days	Number of calendar days from t through t+6 on which at least one retained Public Papers document is issued.
Mapped Survey Share	Share of weighted first responses in the latest available Most Important Problem survey that can be mapped to a policy area.
Survey Age	Calendar days between t and the end of fieldwork for the latest available prior Most Important Problem survey. A survey becomes available on the day after fieldwork ends.
Approval Survey Age	Calendar days since fieldwork ended for the latest presidential-approval survey that strictly predates t, divided by 30.
Meeting-topic Shares	Vector of normalized potential meeting-area shares across the 20 policy areas. Public Lands is omitted.
D. Market uncertainty and return variables	
GJR-GARCH Abnormal Volatility	Log root-mean-square standardized market shock over the five trading days beginning after the last actual public communication in the t-through-t+6 window: 0.5×ln(mean(z²)), where z is the residual from a GJR-GARCH(1,1) model for the daily market excess return divided by its conditional standard deviation.
Realized Variance	Natural logarithm of the mean squared daily market excess return over the five trading days beginning after the last actual public communication in the forward window.
FF48 Dispersion	Natural logarithm of the mean daily cross-sectional standard deviation of Fama–French 48-industry returns over the five post-communication trading days. A daily dispersion observation requires returns for at least 40 industries.
Pre-communication Market Uncertainty [TD−5, TD−1], GJR-GARCH	GJR-GARCH log root-mean-square standardized market shock over the five trading days immediately before the post-communication outcome window.

Variable	Definition
Pre-communication Market Uncertainty [TD−22, TD−6], GJR-GARCH	GJR-GARCH log root-mean-square standardized market shock over the preceding nonoverlapping 17-trading-day window.
Pre-communication Market Uncertainty [TD−43, TD−22], GJR-GARCH	GJR-GARCH log root-mean-square standardized market shock over the earlier 22-trading-day window used as a lagged control in the placebo specification.
Pre-communication Market Uncertainty, Realized Variance	Realized-variance state measured as ln(mean market excess return²). The recent state uses [TD−5, TD−1]; the longer state used in estimation uses [TD−22, TD−1].
Pre-communication Market Uncertainty, FF48 Dispersion	FF48 dispersion state measured as ln(mean daily cross-industry standard deviation). The recent state uses [TD−5, TD−1]; the longer state used in estimation uses [TD−22, TD−1].
Pre-communication Market Return	Cumulative Fama–French market excess return over the trading-day window shown in the table. The principal recent and earlier windows are [TD−5, TD−1] and [TD−22, TD−6]; the earlier placebo control uses [TD−43, TD−22].
Industry-Portfolio Volatility	The log root mean square of daily excess-return residuals for a June-fixed, equal-weighted industry portfolio over the five post-communication trading days. Daily residuals come from a rolling Fama–French three-factor regression estimated using the preceding 252 trading days, excluding the current day and requiring at least 126 observations. Each industry-day requires at least five firms.
Within-Industry Dispersion	For each trading day, the cross-sectional standard deviation of firm-level residuals from rolling Fama–French three-factor regressions within an industry. The variable is the log root mean square of these daily standard deviations over the five post-communication trading days. Each industry-day requires at least five firms.
Political Exposure	Following Belo, Gala, and Li (2013), the total direct and indirect output required from an industry to satisfy federal, state, and local government final demand, divided by the industry's total output. The measure is constructed from BEA benchmark input-output tables and assigned to July–June formation years using public-release benchmark vintages. The main analysis excludes formation years whose SIC-to-I-O mapping depends on the unavailable 1982 concordance. Industries are defined using three-digit SIC before 2003 and the most detailed matched NAICS prefix from 2003 onward. The measure is standardized within formation year across matched firms in firm-level regressions and across represented industries in industry-level regressions.
E. Firm-level uncertainty and return variables	
Idiosyncratic Volatility	For each firm, 0.5×ln(mean residual²) over the five post-disclosure trading days. Daily residuals come from a rolling Fama–French three-factor regression estimated only with the preceding 252 trading days, excluding the current day and requiring at least 126 observations.
Excess Return Uncertainty	For each firm, log root-mean-square standardized excess return over the five post-disclosure trading days. Each daily excess return is standardized using the firm's mean and standard deviation estimated from the preceding 252 trading days, excluding the current day and requiring at least 126 observations.
Pre-communication Firm Return Uncertainty	Firm-level log root-mean-square standardized excess return, constructed as for Excess Return Uncertainty, over [TD−5, TD−1] or [TD−22, TD−6] as shown in the table.

Variable	Definition
Pre-communication Firm Return	Cumulative firm excess return over [TD−5, TD−1] or [TD−22, TD−6] as shown in the table.

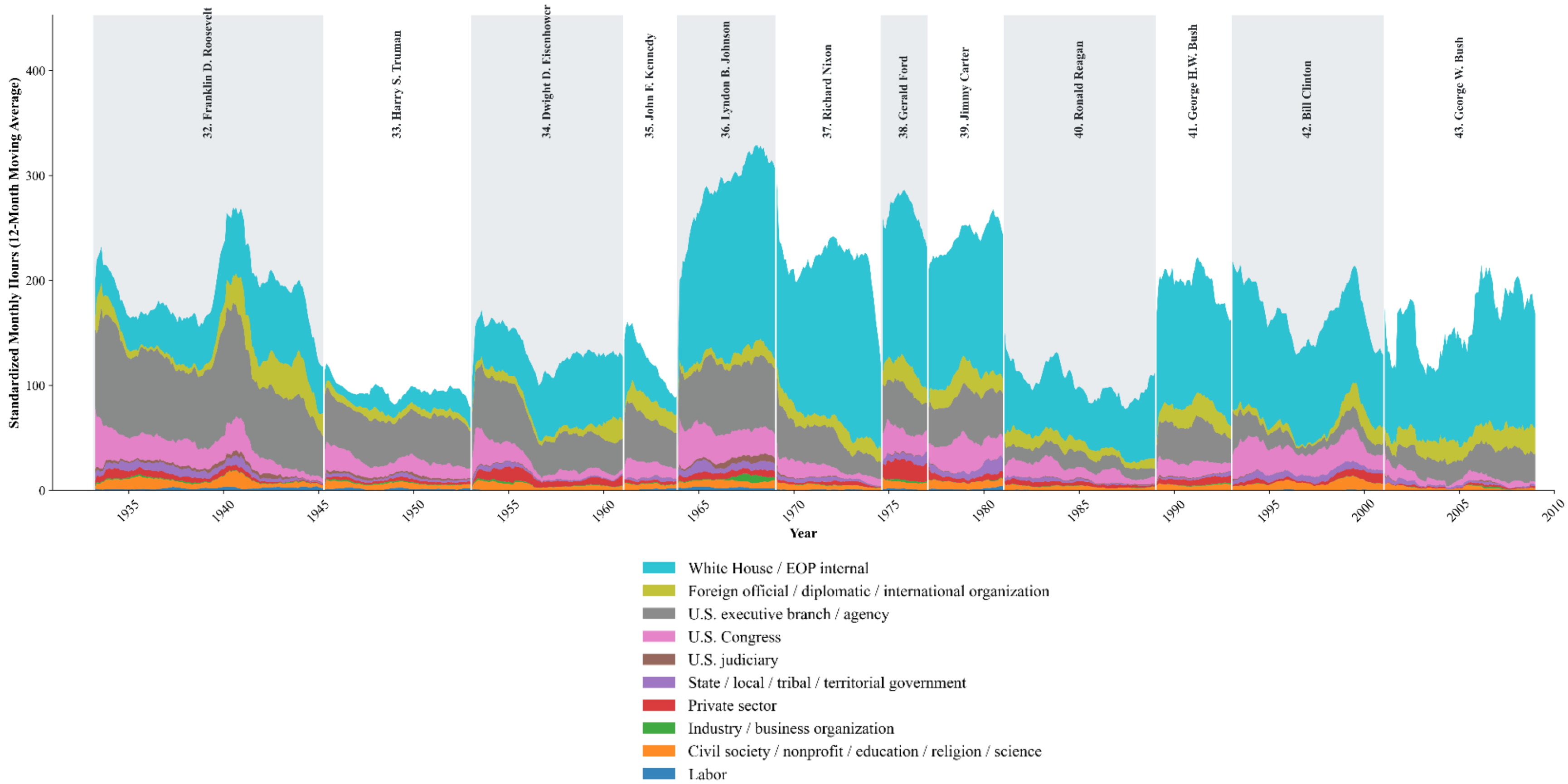
Note: This table defines the constructed variables used in the empirical tables. Date t is the date of the presidential meetings. Unless otherwise stated, the forward window is [t, t+6] and the backward window is [t−7, t−1]; neither window crosses presidential terms. P and Q denote meeting-topic and communication-topic shares, respectively. TD denotes trading day relative to the post-communication outcome window. CAP is the Comparative Agendas Project; GJR-GARCH is the Glosten–Jagannathan–Runkle generalized autoregressive conditional heteroskedasticity model; FF48 denotes the Fama–French 48-industry portfolios. Simple interaction terms are products of their constituent variables.

Figure 1. Presidential Time Allocation among Various Activities



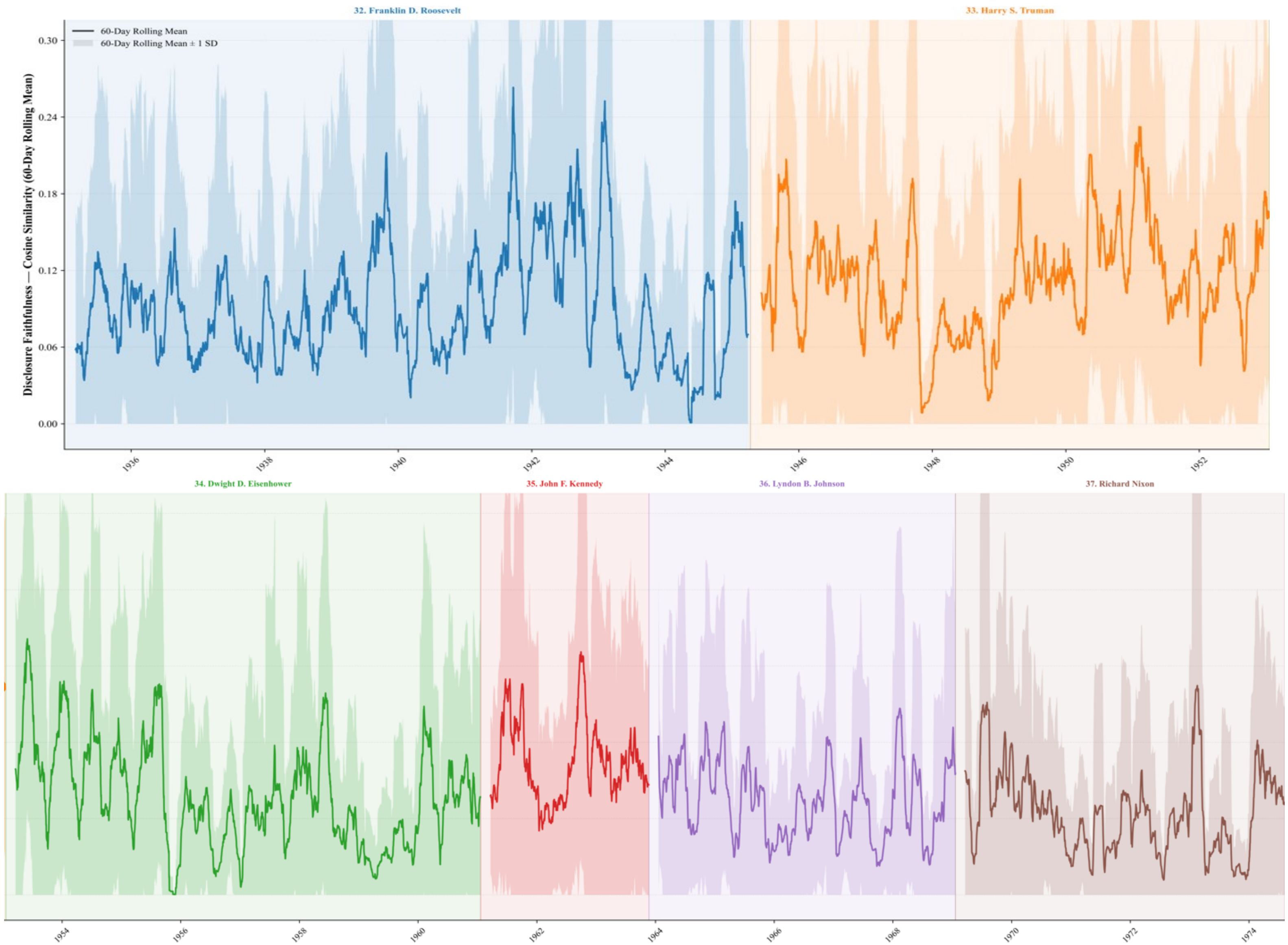
Note: This figure presents the composition of presidential activities over time. The underlying data is unfiltered Presidential Daily Diary. Activity type is identified using LLM (Gemini-3.1-Pro) based on the activity description provided by the Presidential Daily Diary. Taxonomy of the activity types can be found in Appendix B. The figure reports a 12-month moving average of standardized monthly hours, calculated separately within each presidential administration so that the moving-average window does not span presidential transitions. Colors distinguish activity categories, and presidential administrations are shown as separate periods.

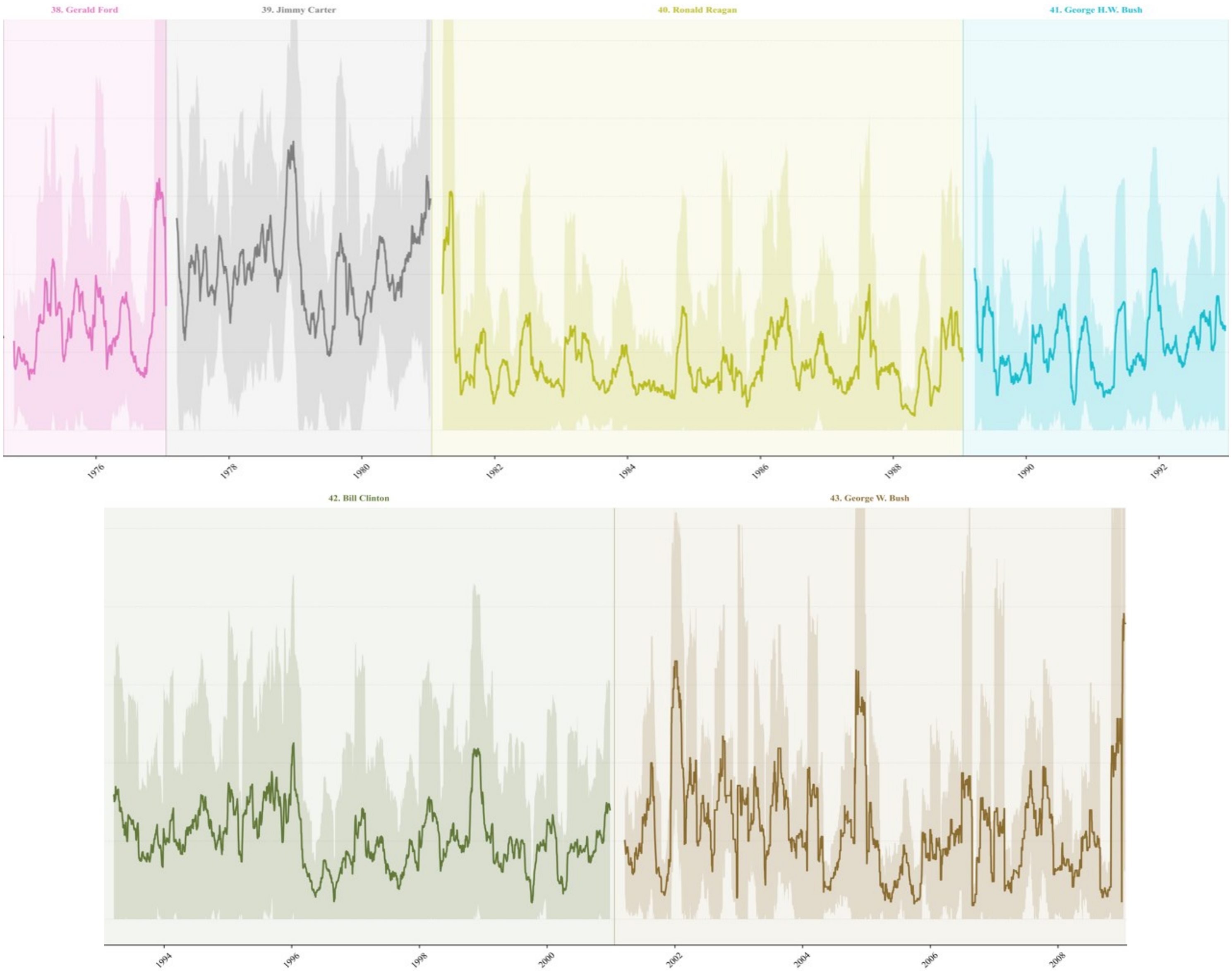
Figure 2. Counterparty Distribution of Presidential Meetings across Time



Note: This figure presents the composition of presidential meetings by counterparty type over time. The underlying data is unfiltered Presidential Daily Diary, and counterparty type is identified using LLM (Gemini-3.1-Pro) based on the counterparties' titles provided by the Presidential Daily Diary. Taxonomy of the counterparty types can be found in Appendix C. The figure retains the ten counterparty categories specified in the classification procedure. The figure reports a 12-month moving average of standardized monthly hours, calculated separately within each presidential administration so that the moving-average window does not span presidential transitions. Colors distinguish counterparty categories, and presidential administrations are shown as separate periods.

Figure 3. Presidential Communication Topic Similarity





Note: This figure presents the time-series evolution of the *Topic Similarity* measure. For each calendar day, the solid line reports the mean of all nonmissing daily *Topic Similarity* in the preceding 60 calendar days, and the shaded region reports the rolling mean plus or minus one standard deviation. The rolling calculations are performed separately within each presidential administration.

Table 1. Descriptive Statistics

variable_label	N	Mean	P25	P50	P75	SD	Min	Max
Topic Similarity	15,870	0.0765	0.0067	0.0386	0.1056	0.1008	0.0000	0.9363
Voter Salience	15,870	0.0697	0.0346	0.0551	0.0868	0.0556	0.0000	0.6125
Own-party Conflict	15,870	0.0361	0.0000	0.0000	0.0722	0.0433	0.0000	0.4758
Inter-party Conflict	15,870	0.1676	0.0000	0.1642	0.2683	0.1619	0.0000	0.7179
Ln(Number of Meetings + 1)	15,870	2.3050	1.7918	2.3026	2.9444	0.8291	0.6931	3.9318
Ln(Meeting Length + 1)	15,870	5.1125	4.5486	5.3254	5.9877	1.1833	0.6931	6.9037
Topic Concentration	15,870	0.3888	0.2082	0.3185	0.5000	0.2475	0.0182	1.0000
Topic Concentration^2	15,870	0.2124	0.0433	0.1015	0.2500	0.2688	0.0003	1.0000
Ln(Number of Communication Events + 1)	15,870	2.4520	2.0794	2.4849	2.8904	0.6260	0.6931	3.6109
Number of Communication Days	15,870	4.8823	4.0000	5.0000	6.0000	1.4722	1.0000	7.0000
Backward Topic Similarity	15,870	0.0733	0.0057	0.0363	0.1015	0.0993	0.0000	0.9480
Mapped Survey Share	15,870	0.8878	0.8590	0.9090	0.9465	0.0861	0.0769	0.9824
Survey Age	15,870	90.5744	16.0000	39.0000	84.0000	153.1143	1.0000	1140.0000
Own-party Conflict Coverage	15,870	0.9979	1.0000	1.0000	1.0000	0.0138	0.5000	1.0000
Inter-party Conflict Coverage	15,870	0.9991	1.0000	1.0000	1.0000	0.0094	0.5792	1.0000
Relative Area Emphasis	152,024	0.2730	0.0000	0.1311	0.5132	0.3145	0.0000	1.0000
Area Under-emphasis	152,024	0.4960	0.0000	0.4834	1.0000	0.4590	0.0000	1.0000
Voter Salience_Area	152,024	0.0562	0.0000	0.0115	0.0493	0.1122	0.0000	0.7746
Own-party Conflict_ Area	152,024	0.0435	0.0000	0.0000	0.0704	0.0677	0.0000	0.7037
Inter-party Conflict_ Area	152,024	0.1466	0.0000	0.0948	0.2435	0.1735	0.0000	0.8027
Area Share	152,024	0.0975	0.0050	0.0194	0.0925	0.1772	0.0010	0.9987
Area Share^2	152,024	0.0409	0.0000	0.0004	0.0086	0.1250	0.0000	0.9974
Own-party Conflict Coverage_ Area	152,024	0.9937	1.0000	1.0000	1.0000	0.0560	0.5000	1.0000
Inter-party Conflict Coverage_ Area	152,024	0.9973	1.0000	1.0000	1.0000	0.0365	0.5000	1.0000
Backward Area Under-emphasis	152,024	0.5018	0.0000	0.5104	1.0000	0.4592	0.0000	1.0000
Backward Area Over-emphasis	152,024	0.2290	0.0000	0.0000	0.4823	0.3422	0.0000	0.9968
Area Omission	152,024	0.3876	0.0000	0.0000	1.0000	0.4872	0.0000	1.0000
Backward Area Omission	152,024	0.3925	0.0000	0.0000	1.0000	0.4883	0.0000	1.0000

Area Over-emphasis	92,524	0.3779	0.0000	0.3071	0.7510	0.3695	0.0000	0.9969
Within-Area Similarity_Hellinger Affinity	75,097	0.3294	0.0237	0.2887	0.5594	0.2937	0.0000	1.0000
Within-Area Similarity_Cosine Similarity	75,097	0.2729	0.0007	0.1224	0.4911	0.3196	0.0000	1.0000
Within-area Topic Concentration	75,097	0.5836	0.3777	0.5427	0.8033	0.2452	0.0912	1.0000
Within-area Topic Concentration ^{2}	75,097	0.4007	0.1426	0.2945	0.6452	0.3019	0.0083	0.9999
-ΔArea Share	75,097	-0.0251	-0.0394	-0.0007	0.0543	0.1923	-0.9992	0.9969
Has Prior Communicated	75,097	0.7364	0.0000	1.0000	1.0000	0.4406	0.0000	1.0000
Disapproval	13,937	1.1972	0.0000	2.0000	2.0000	0.8827	0.0000	2.0000
Approval Survey Age	13,937	0.4868	0.1333	0.3000	0.5667	0.6848	0.0333	7.4333
Presidential Candidate	2,028	0.5158	0.0000	1.0000	1.0000	0.4999	0.0000	1.0000
Election Proximity	2,028	0.4840	0.2391	0.4837	0.7337	0.2846	0.0000	0.9674
Funding Pressure	3,909	0.3009	0.0000	0.1429	0.5714	0.3504	0.0000	1.0000
Shutdown	1,431	0.0224	0.0000	0.0000	0.0000	0.1479	0.0000	1.0000
Funding Gap without Shutdown	1,431	0.0021	0.0000	0.0000	0.0000	0.0458	0.0000	1.0000
Post-communication Market Uncertainty: GJR-GARCH	15,871	-0.1839	-0.4182	-0.1541	0.0799	0.4005	-3.0195	1.5147
Post-communication Market Uncertainty: Realized Variance	15,871	-10.2269	-10.9231	-10.2319	-9.5278	1.1105	-14.8768	-4.7851
Post-communication Market Uncertainty: FF48 Dispersion	15,871	-4.8525	-5.0391	-4.8930	-4.7379	0.2906	-5.5256	-3.3971
Political Exposure	2,022,408	0.0285	−0.6865	−0.2027	0.3941	1.0237	−4.8906	8.4247
Industry-Portfolio Volatility	2,022,408	−4.8633	−5.2911	−4.8664	−4.4361	0.6548	−8.5267	−0.6502
Within-Industry Dispersion	2,022,356	−3.5114	−3.8649	−3.5318	−3.1706	0.5163	−6.3188	0.3817
Idiosyncratic Volatility	58,766,022	-3.9491	-4.4895	-3.9206	-3.3513	0.9286	-42.6617	1.6031
Excess Return Uncertainty	58,766,022	-0.4163	-0.6867	-0.2628	0.1088	0.9396	-16.6115	21.6126

Notes: This table reports statistics before absorbed fixed-effect singleton removal. The sample runs from January 1, 1947 through January 14, 2009. Unbounded continuous variables are winsorized at the 1st and 99th percentiles. Variable definitions appear in Appendix H.

Table 2. Topic Similarity and Political Incentives

	Dependent Variable: Topic Similarity							
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Voter Salience	**0.1588*** (6.69)**	**0.1866*** (7.60)**	**0.1511*** (6.22)**	**0.1767*** (6.94)**	**0.1554*** (6.72)**	**0.1799*** (7.76)**	**0.1473*** (6.25)**	**0.1696*** (7.09)**
Own-party Conflict			**−0.1730** (−2.13)**	**-0.1726** (-2.01)**			**−0.1798** (−2.22)**	**-0.1802** (-2.12)**
Inter-party Conflict					**−0.0628* (−1.67)**	**-0.1167*** (-2.66)**	**−0.0659* (−1.75)**	**-0.1187*** (-2.69)**
Ln(Number of Meetings + 1)	−0.0017 (−0.90)	-0.0000 (-0.02)	−0.0017 (−0.92)	-0.0001 (-0.07)	−0.0014 (−0.76)	0.0004 (0.21)	−0.0014 (−0.78)	0.0003 (0.16)
Ln(Meeting Length + 1)	−0.0005 (−0.46)	-0.0007 (-0.81)	−0.0006 (−0.53)	-0.0008 (-0.87)	−0.0003 (−0.33)	-0.0005 (-0.50)	−0.0004 (−0.40)	-0.0005 (-0.56)
Topic Concentration	−0.2100*** (−13.89)	-0.2332*** (-15.56)	−0.2128*** (−13.96)	-0.2361*** (-15.65)	−0.2093*** (−13.83)	-0.2319*** (-15.49)	−0.2121*** (−13.89)	-0.2349*** (-15.58)
Topic Concentration^2	0.1286*** (9.34)	0.1441*** (10.93)	0.1302*** (9.41)	0.1456*** (10.98)	0.1295*** (9.45)	0.1460*** (11.17)	0.1312*** (9.53)	0.1476*** (11.23)
Ln(Number of Communication Events +1)	0.0081* (1.79)	0.0130** (2.20)	0.0082* (1.80)	0.0131** (2.23)	0.0081* (1.75)	0.0132** (2.24)	0.0081* (1.77)	0.0133** (2.27)
Ln(Number of Communication Days +1)	0.0017 (1.00)	0.0011 (0.61)	0.0017 (0.99)	0.0011 (0.59)	0.0017 (0.98)	0.0010 (0.55)	0.0017 (0.97)	0.0009 (0.53)
Backward Topic Similarity	0.1229*** (6.05)	0.0355 (1.43)	0.1228*** (6.08)	0.0351 (1.42)	0.1223*** (6.02)	0.0337 (1.36)	0.1221*** (6.04)	0.0333 (1.35)
Mapped Survey Share	−0.0790*** (−3.73)	0.0145 (0.28)	−0.0778*** (−3.76)	0.0135 (0.26)	−0.0789*** (−3.73)	0.0177 (0.35)	−0.0777*** (−3.76)	0.0167 (0.33)
Survey Age	−0.0000 (−1.10)	-0.0000 (-1.05)	−0.0000 (−0.93)	-0.0000 (-1.11)	−0.0000 (−1.05)	-0.0000 (-1.08)	−0.0000 (−0.89)	-0.0000 (-1.14)
Own-party Conflict Coverage			0.1229** (2.01)	0.1746*** (2.74)			0.1238** (2.03)	0.1756*** (2.76)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Inter-party Conflict Coverage					0.0768 (0.91)	0.0834 (0.78)	0.0777 (0.91)	0.0856 (0.79)
President-Year FE	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes	No
President-Year-Month FE	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes
Weekday FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Obs.	15,871	15,870	15,871	15,870	15,871	15,870	15,871	15,870
Adj. R^2	0.145	0.225	0.146	0.226	0.146	0.226	0.147	0.227

Notes. This table reports daily regressions of presidential communication topic similarity. Variable definitions can be found in Appendix I. All specifications include the controls shown, president-year-month and weekday fixed effects. Two-sided t-statistics, based on standard errors clustered by president-year, are in parentheses. ***, **, and * denote significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively.

Table 3. Decomposition of Communication Similarity – Area Allocation

Dependent Variables	(1) *Relative Area Emphasis*	(2) *Area Under-emphasis*	(3) *Area Omission*	(4) *Area Over-emphasis*
Voter Salience_Area	**0.0897*** **(3.64)**	**-0.2040*** **(-4.46)**	**-0.1486*** **(-3.60)**	**0.0401** **(1.50)**
Own-party Conflict_ Area	**-0.0364** **(-1.43)**	**0.0818*** **(1.87)**	**0.1326*** **(2.77)**	**0.0453** **(1.15)**
Inter-party Conflict_ Area	**-0.0109** **(-0.69)**	**-0.0585** **(-1.45)**	**-0.0363** **(-1.05)**	**0.0881*** **(2.87)**
Area Share	0.6582*** (14.79)	1.1248*** (19.32)	-0.1735*** (-6.51)	-2.5697*** (-45.69)
Area Share^2	-0.9604*** (-18.36)	-0.6276*** (-11.63)	0.1762*** (5.63)	2.3568*** (33.15)
Own-party Conflict Coverage	-0.0088 (-0.26)	-0.0161 (-0.25)	-0.0167 (-0.22)	0.0542 (1.31)
Inter-party Conflict Coverage	-0.0086 (-0.37)	-0.0258 (-0.61)	-0.0202 (-0.39)	0.0642 (1.57)
Backward Area Under-emphasis	-0.1896*** (-25.19)	0.0834*** (11.33)		0.1691*** (25.84)
Backward Area Omission			0.0680*** (12.42)	
Backward Area Over-emphasis	-0.2840*** (-24.44)	-0.0132* (-1.75)		0.3946*** (30.82)
President-Date FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
President-Area FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Number of President-day	14,837	14,837	14,837	14,122
Obs.	152,024	152,024	152,024	92,524
Adj. R^2	0.327	0.297	0.343	0.549

Notes. This table reports policy area-level decompositions of presidential disclosure. Variable definitions can be found in Appendix I. All specifications include president-date and president-by-Area fixed effects. Two-sided t-statistics use standard errors clustered by president-year. ***, **, and * denote significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively.

Table 4. Decomposition of Communication Similarity – Within-area Similarity

Dependent Variable	*Within-area Similarity*	
	(1) *HellingerAffinity*	(2) *Cosine Similarity*
Voter Salience_Area	**0.0855**** **(2.21)**	**0.0736*** **(1.75)**
Own-party Conflict_ Area	**-0.0146** **(-0.22)**	**-0.0375** **(-0.52)**
Inter-party Conflict_ Area	**0.0001** **(0.00)**	**-0.0148** **(-0.42)**
Area Share	0.1382*** (3.68)	0.0312 (0.83)
Area Share^2	-0.1263*** (-3.53)	-0.0380 (-1.04)
Within-Area Topic Concentration	-0.2937*** (-11.01)	-0.4868*** (-16.62)
Within-Area Topic Concentration^2	0.0947*** (4.14)	0.2473*** (10.01)
Own-party Conflict Coverage	-0.0273 (-0.48)	-0.0066 (-0.12)
Inter-party Conflict Coverage	0.0578 (0.65)	0.0800 (0.79)
-ΔArea Share	0.0191 (1.09)	-0.0024 (-0.12)
Has Prior Communicated	0.0066 (1.57)	0.0062 (1.36)
President-Date FE	Yes	Yes
President-Area FE	Yes	Yes
Number of President-day	10,859	10,859
Obs.	75,097	75,097
Adj. R^2	0.150	0.122

Notes. This table reports within-Area Similarity regressions. The unit of observation is a president-date-area with positive distribution shares and at least two topics in the potential meeting topic distribution. Both topic vectors are renormalized within the Area. The measure labeled Hellinger Affinity is the Bhattacharyya/Hellinger affinity; larger values in both columns indicate greater within Area Topic Similarity. All specifications include president-date and president-by-Area fixed effects. Two-sided t-statistics use president-year-clustered standard errors. ***, **, and * denote significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively.

Table 5. Topic Similarity and Disapproval

	All Observations		14 Days after Approval Surveys	
Dependent Variable: Topic Similarity	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Disapproval	**0.0120*** (2.66)**	**0.0111** (2.54)**	**0.0092*** (2.81)**	**0.0082** (2.61)**
Disapproval × Voter Salience		**0.0140 (0.49)**		**0.0733** (2.03)**
Disapproval × Own-party Conflict		**-0.1300 (-1.10)**		**-0.2557*** (-2.78)**
Disapproval × Inter-party Conflict		**0.0005 (0.02)**		**-0.0170 (-0.74)**
Voter Salience	0.1446*** (6.08)	0.1256*** (2.92)	0.1391*** (3.75)	0.0390 (0.72)
Own-party Conflict	-0.2484*** (-3.27)	-0.0393 (-0.18)	-0.2183** (-2.13)	0.2102 (1.28)
Inter-party Conflict	-0.1200*** (-2.85)	-0.1212*** (-2.76)	-0.1323*** (-2.74)	-0.1203** (-2.37)
Ln(Number of Meetings + 1)	0.0011 (0.52)	0.0011 (0.53)	0.0014 (0.61)	0.0015 (0.68)
Ln(Meeting Length + 1)	-0.0008 (-0.80)	-0.0008 (-0.79)	-0.0009 (-0.91)	-0.0009 (-1.01)
Topic Concentration	-0.2360*** (-15.61)	-0.2358*** (-15.57)	-0.2443*** (-13.73)	-0.2425*** (-13.60)
Topic Concentration^2	0.1486*** (11.46)	0.1486*** (11.42)	0.1585*** (9.92)	0.1571*** (9.74)
Ln(Number of Communication Events +1)	0.0138** (2.40)	0.0136** (2.36)	0.0105 (1.46)	0.0101 (1.42)
Ln(Number of Communication Days +1)	0.0011 (0.60)	0.0012 (0.64)	0.0023 (0.98)	0.0024 (1.03)
Backward Topic Similarity	0.0318 (1.25)	0.0313 (1.23)	0.0247 (0.70)	0.0244 (0.70)
Mapped Survey Share	0.0091 (0.19)	0.0084 (0.18)	-0.1067 (-1.22)	-0.1059 (-1.22)
Survey Age	-0.0000 (-1.15)	-0.0000 (-1.14)	-0.0001 (-0.73)	-0.0000 (-0.68)
Own-party Conflict Coverage	0.1835*** (2.84)	0.1800*** (2.78)	0.2072* (1.78)	0.1958 (1.64)
Inter-party Conflict Coverage	0.0868 (0.82)	0.0862 (0.81)	-0.0260 (-0.45)	-0.0335 (-0.57)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Approval Survey Age	-0.0034 (-0.68)	-0.0033 (-0.66)	0.0032 (0.23)	0.0035 (0.25)
President-Year-Month FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Weekday FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Obs.	13,937	13,937	9,566	9,566
Adj. R^2	0.225	0.225	0.265	0.267

Notes. This table examines whether presidential approval conditions *Topic Similarity*. The variable labeled Disapproval is an ordinal, president-specific vulnerability state based on the latest strictly prior approval survey: zero if current approval/(approval+disapproval) is at or above the president's prior median, one if it is below the median but above the prior bottom quartile, and two if it is in the prior bottom quartile. Classification requires at least five prior survey events. Columns (1)-(2) impose no maximum survey age; columns (3)-(4) require a survey within 14 days. Interaction specifications center the benefit and cost variables within the estimation sample. All models control for survey age and include the baseline controls, president-year-month and weekday fixed effects. Two-sided t-statistics use president-year-clustered standard errors. ***, **, and * denote significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels.

Table 6. Topic Similarity and Reelection

	Dependent Variable: Topic Similarity			
Benchmark	(1) Preceding Same-president Midterm	(2) Preceding Same-president Midterm	(3) All Same-president Midterm	(4) All Same-president Midterm
Election proximity	**-0.0308** **(-0.50)**	**-0.0481** **(-0.62)**	**-0.0500** **(-1.01)**	**-0.1362**** **(-2.30)**
Presidential Candidate × Election proximity	**0.0676***** **(4.68)**	**0.0991**** **(2.31)**	**0.0373***** **(2.99)**	**0.1135***** **(4.15)**
Presidential Candidate × Election proximity × Voter Salience		**0.6669** **(1.68)**		**0.4463** **(1.31)**
Presidential Candidate × Election proximity × Own-party Conflict		**-0.6550** **(-1.54)**		**-1.2309**** **(-2.29)**
Presidential Candidate × Election proximity × Inter-party Conflict		**-0.3112*** **(-1.84)**		**-0.4163***** **(-3.89)**
Voter Salience	0.1053* (2.02)	0.0980 (0.67)	0.1076*** (3.18)	0.0334 (0.42)
Own-party Conflict	-0.4381* (-1.76)	-0.2887 (-1.13)	-0.4472** (-2.48)	-0.8151*** (-3.40)
Inter-party Conflict	-0.0318 (-0.57)	-0.1031 (-0.81)	-0.1140** (-2.45)	-0.3917*** (-3.48)
Election proximity × Voter Salience		0.0511 (0.23)		0.1376 (0.69)
Election proximity × Own-party Conflict		-0.0915 (-0.29)		0.8139* (1.78)
Election proximity × Inter-party Conflict		0.1451 (1.06)		0.3506** (2.72)

Presidential Candidate × Voter Salience		-0.3533 (-1.69)		-0.1954 (-1.22)
Presidential Candidate × Own-party Conflict		-0.5680 (-1.41)		0.5099 (1.15)
Presidential Candidate × Inter-party Conflict		0.1524 (1.05)		0.3757*** (3.32)
Ln(Number of Meetings + 1)	0.0013 (0.27)	0.0011 (0.22)	0.0042 (1.13)	0.0033 (0.88)
Ln(Meeting Length + 1)	-0.0022 (-0.81)	-0.0022 (-0.82)	-0.0021 (-1.03)	-0.0019 (-0.95)
Topic Concentration	-0.2767*** (-7.75)	-0.2760*** (-7.51)	-0.2418*** (-8.61)	-0.2430*** (-8.82)
Topic Concentration^2	0.1872*** (5.97)	0.1874*** (5.94)	0.1563*** (6.06)	0.1573*** (6.18)
Ln(Number of Communication Events +1)	0.0096 (0.92)	0.0118 (1.11)	0.0187* (2.01)	0.0215** (2.20)
Ln(Number of Communication Days +1)	0.0025 (0.63)	0.0019 (0.49)	0.0010 (0.36)	0.0001 (0.04)
Backward Topic Similarity	0.1828*** (2.99)	0.1750** (2.82)	0.1538** (2.51)	0.1469** (2.44)
Mapped Survey Share	-0.0320 (-1.00)	-0.0106 (-0.25)	-0.089* (-2.01)	-0.0900 (-1.52)
Survey Age	-0.0000 (-0.98)	0.0000 (0.15)	-0.0000 (-1.53)	-0.0000 (-1.30)
Own-party Conflict Coverage	0.6175* (1.91)	0.6526* (2.08)	0.4305** (2.67)	0.4619** (2.74)
Inter-party Conflict Coverage	-0.1077 (-1.36)	-0.1066 (-1.44)	0.0022 (0.07)	-0.0292 (-0.57)
Election Event FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Relative Month to Election FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Weekday FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Horizon	6 Months	6 Months	6 Months	6 Months

Number of Presidents (Elections)	8 (16)	8 (16)	10 (24)	10 (24)
Obs.	2,028	2,028	3,103	3,103
Adj. R^2	0.307	0.311	0.251	0.256

Notes. This table examines Topic Similarity during the six calendar months preceding federal elections. Presidential Candidate equals one when the incumbent is actively seeking continued presidential tenure in the forthcoming presidential election; Election Proximity increases linearly from zero at the start of the window to one on Election Day. The full seven-day disclosure window must end before Election Day. Columns (1)-(2) compare each candidacy election with the same president's immediately preceding midterm; columns (3)-(4) use all same-president midterms. The models include the baseline controls and election-event, relative-election-month, and weekday fixed effects. Two-sided t-statistics use standard errors clustered by election event. ***, **, and * denote significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively.

Table 7. Topic Similarity and Budgetary Pressure

Dependent Variable: Topic Similarity	Full History		Post-Civiletti Opinion	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Funding Pressure	**-0.0004** **(-0.04)**	**-0.0114** **(-0.91)**	**0.0329**** **(2.19)**	**0.0278*** **(2.04)**
Funding Pressure × Post-Civiletti Opinion		**0.0366**** **(2.07)**		
Shutdown				**0.0942**** **(2.54)**
Funding Gap without Shutdown				**-0.0092** **(-0.94)**
Voter Salience	0.1837** (2.59)	0.1838** (2.59)	0.1076 (0.97)	0.0955 (0.87)
Own-party Conflict	-0.3720*** (-3.60)	-0.3731*** (-3.61)	0.0423 (0.14)	0.0339 (0.12)
Inter-party Conflict	-0.0172 (-0.29)	-0.0165 (-0.27)	0.0397 (0.62)	0.0258 (0.41)
Ln(Number of Meetings + 1)	0.0039 (1.12)	0.0040 (1.13)	0.0044 (0.99)	0.0037 (0.89)
Ln(Meeting Length + 1)	-0.0018 (-0.87)	-0.0018 (-0.88)	-0.0026 (-0.95)	-0.0031 (-1.02)
Topic Concentration	-0.2463*** (-9.10)	-0.2480*** (-9.27)	-0.2276*** (-8.06)	-0.2357*** (-7.63)
Topic Concentration^2	0.1549*** (6.62)	0.1565*** (6.78)	0.1447*** (6.37)	0.1526*** (6.26)
Ln(Number of Communication Events +1)	0.0218* (1.99)	0.0220** (2.02)	0.0047 (0.24)	0.0110 (0.66)

Ln(Number of Communication Days +1)	-0.0021 (-0.60)	-0.0021 (-0.62)	0.0002 (0.04)	0.0000 (0.01)
Backward Topic Similarity	0.0399 (1.20)	0.0394 (1.20)	0.1896*** (2.81)	0.1854** (2.70)
Mapped Survey Share	0.0053 (0.05)	-0.0149 (-0.18)	-0.0008 (-0.01)	0.0160 (0.17)
Survey Age	-0.0001 (-1.15)	-0.0001 (-1.21)	-0.0000 (-0.05)	-0.0001 (-0.35)
Own-party Conflict Coverage	0.0312 (0.25)	0.0275 (0.21)	Omitted	Omitted
Inter-party Conflict Coverage	0.2191** (2.45)	0.2258** (2.52)	-0.0437 (-0.01)	-0.6577 (-0.19)
Funding Episode	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
President-Year-Month FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Weekday FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Included Obs: 28 Days Prior to Deadlines	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Included Obs: Funding Gaps	No	No	Yes	Yes
Obs.	3,909	3,909	1,431	1,431
Adj. R^2	0.228	0.231	0.330	0.344

Notes. This table examines Topic Similarity around federal funding deadlines. Funding Pressure is zero outside the final 14 days before a deadline and rises linearly as the deadline approaches; active funding-gap days are excluded from this countdown. The modern Antideficiency Act enforcement regime begins on January 16, 1981. Columns (1)-(2) use the full historical sample. Columns (3)-(4) use the modern regime within a local 28-day deadline window and retain active failure days; column (4) distinguishes an operational shutdown from an ordinary funding gap without shutdown. The models include the baseline controls and president-by-funding-episode, president-year-month, and weekday fixed effects. Two-sided t-statistics use standard errors two-way clustered by funding episode and president-year. ***, **, and * denote significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels.

Table 8. Topic Similarity and Market Uncertainty

Dependent Variables: Post-communication Market Uncertainty	*GJR-GARCH*			*Realized Variance*	FF48 Dispersion
	(1) B5	(2) B6	(3) B7	(4) C5	(5) J3
Topic Similarity	**-0.1338***** **(-3.05)**	**-0.1385***** **(-3.11)**	**-0.1371***** **(-3.08)**	**-0.2640***** **(-2.96)**	**-0.0448***** **(-3.05)**
Pre-communication *Market Uncertainty [TD−5,TD−1], GJR-GARCH*	-0.2202*** (-13.81)	-0.2202*** (-13.84)	-0.2205*** (-13.85)	0.2680** (2.56)	
Pre-communication *Market Uncertainty [TD−22,TD−6], GJR-GARCH*	-0.3019*** (-7.50)	-0.3017*** (-7.48)	-0.3022*** (-7.50)		
Pre-communication *Market Uncertainty [TD−5,TD−1], Realized Variance*				-0.2535*** (-4.39)	
Pre-communication *Market Uncertainty [TD−22,TD−6], Realized Variance*				-0.1847*** (-3.10)	
Pre-communication *Market Uncertainty [TD−5,TD−1],* FF48 Dispersion					-0.0882*** (-4.26)
Pre-communication *Market Uncertainty [TD−22,TD−6],* FF48 Dispersion					-0.3264*** (-6.36)
Pre-communication *Market Return [TD−5,TD−1]*	1.2679*** (3.90)	1.2663*** (3.90)	1.2657*** (3.89)		-0.4705*** (-3.11)
Pre-communication *Market Return [TD−22,TD−6]*	1.2568*** (5.21)	1.2544*** (5.20)	1.2556*** (5.20)		-0.2118** (-2.17)
Ln(Number of Communication Events +1)	-0.0006 (-0.03)	-0.0009 (-0.04)	-0.0014 (-0.06)	0.0248 (0.55)	0.0098 (1.23)
Ln(Number of Communication Days +1)	-0.0134* (-1.72)	-0.0137* (-1.75)	-0.0138* (-1.77)	-0.0284* (-1.81)	-0.0063** (-2.10)
Ln(Number of Meetings + 1)	0.0061 (0.92)	0.0085 (1.23)	0.0084 (1.21)	0.0079 (0.55)	0.0003 (0.11)

Ln(Meeting Length + 1)	-0.0005 (-0.13)	-0.0009 (-0.23)	-0.0007 (-0.20)	0.0050 (0.66)	0.0016 (1.22)
Topic Concentration	-0.0401 (-0.77)	-0.0086 (-0.15)	-0.0095 (-0.17)	-0.0338 (-0.30)	-0.0130 (-0.67)
Topic Concentration^2	0.0268 (0.57)	0.0093 (0.19)	0.0103 (0.21)	0.0332 (0.35)	0.0172 (1.05)
Backward Topic Similarity	0.0229 (0.55)	0.0189 (0.45)	0.0186 (0.44)	-0.0373 (-0.43)	-0.0240 (-1.53)
Voter Salience			-0.0319 (-0.36)	0.0982 (0.54)	0.0566* (1.86)
Own-party Conflict			0.3454 (1.41)	0.5832 (1.20)	-0.0604 (-0.84)
Inter-party Conflict			0.0455 (0.29)	0.0680 (0.25)	-0.0154 (-0.37)
Mapped Survey Share			0.0608 (0.47)	-0.0530 (-0.19)	-0.0681 (-1.12)
Survey Age			-0.0000 (-0.16)	-0.0003 (-0.68)	-0.0000 (-0.67)
Own-party Conflict Coverage			-0.0272 (-0.11)	0.3754 (0.76)	0.1498** (2.01)
Inter-party Conflict Coverage			0.1120 (0.30)	-0.0973 (-0.12)	0.0490 (0.27)
Private Meeting Area Shares	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year-Month FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Weekday FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Disclosure Length FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Obs.	15,871	15,871	15,871	15,871	15,871
HAC SE	28-Day	28-Day	28-Day	28-Day	28-Day

Notes. This table examines the association between Topic Similarity and market uncertainty after public disclosure. Each outcome covers the five trading days beginning strictly after the last public communication event released from t through t+6. GJR-GARCH Abnormal Volatility is one-half the log mean squared standardized residual from a GJR-GARCH(1,1) model; Realized Variance is the log mean squared market excess return; and FF48 Dispersion is the log mean daily cross-industry return standard deviation, requiring at least 40 industries. Columns progressively add the controls shown. Models include year-month, weekday, and disclosure period length fixed effects. Parentheses report two-sided t-statistics using Bartlett-kernel HAC standard errors with a 28-day maximum lag. TD denotes trading day. ***, **, and * denote significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels.

Table 9: Placebo Test Topic Similarity and Market Uncertainty

	Pre-communication Market Uncertainty *GJR-GARCH*	
	(1) *[TD−5,TD−1]*	(2) *[TD−22,TD−6]*
Topic Similarity	**-0.0606** **(-1.40)**	**0.0015** **(0.08)**
Pre-communication *Market Uncertainty [TD−22,TD−6], GJR-GARCH*	-0.8322*** (-16.22)	
Pre-communication *Market Uncertainty [TD−43,TD−22], GJR-GARCH*		-0.6705*** (-16.96)
Pre-communication *Market Return [TD−22,TD−6]*	-0.9887*** (-3.70)	
Pre-communication *Market Return [TD−43,TD−22]*		0.3703** (2.36)
Ln(Number of Communication Events +1)	-0.0506** (-2.28)	0.0164* (1.88)
Ln(Number of Communication Days +1)	0.0093 (1.18)	-0.0048* (-1.65)
Ln(Number of Meetings + 1)	0.0036 (0.49)	0.0034 (1.18)
Ln(Meeting Length + 1)	-0.0004 (-0.10)	0.0007 (0.51)
Topic Concentration	0.0430 (0.78)	0.0111 (0.53)
Topic Concentration^2	-0.0646 (-1.41)	-0.0105 (-0.60)
Backward Topic Similarity	0.0746 (1.40)	0.0053 (0.28)
Voter Salience	-0.0429 (-0.50)	-0.0160 (-0.49)
Own-party Conflict	0.4346* (1.73)	-0.0370 (-0.46)
Inter-party Conflict	0.0043 (0.04)	-0.0492 (-0.98)
Mapped Survey Share	0.2312* (1.65)	0.0876 (1.22)
Survey Age	-0.0007*** (-2.71)	-0.0001 (-0.94)
Own-party Conflict Coverage	0.4148 (1.49)	0.1417 (1.55)
Inter-party Conflict Coverage	-0.3752 (-1.49)	0.1047 (0.94)

Private Meeting Area Shares	Yes	Yes
Year-Month FE	Yes	Yes
Weekday FE	Yes	Yes
Disclosure Length FE	No	No
Obs.	15,871	15,871
HAC SE	28-Day	28-Day

Notes. This table reports pre-communication placebo tests. Column (1) uses GJR-GARCH abnormal volatility over trading days [TD-5, TD-1] as the outcome and controls for the earlier [TD-22, TD-6] market state. Column (2) uses the 17-trading-day [TD-22, TD-6] GJR-GARCH abnormal-volatility window as the outcome and controls for the still earlier [TD-43, TD-22] market state. Thus, the column (2) outcome window is [TD-22, TD-6], notwithstanding the abbreviated header in the table. Both specifications include the private-meeting, political-incentive, and other controls shown, as well as year-month and weekday fixed effects. Parentheses report two-sided t-statistics using Bartlett-kernel HAC standard errors with a 28-day maximum lag. TD denotes trading day. ***, **, and * denote significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively.

Table 10. Topic Similarity and Firm Return Uncertainty

Dependent Variables	(1) *Idiosyncratic Volatility*	(2) *Excess Return Uncertainty*
Topic Similarity	**-0.0295*** (-5.01)**	**-0.0359*** (-4.54)**
Pre-communication Market Uncertainty [TD−5,TD−1]	-0.0193*** (-10.65)	-0.0360*** (-15.62)
Pre-communication Market Uncertainty [TD−22,TD−6]	-0.0607*** (-14.12)	-0.0991*** (-17.88)
Pre-communication Market Return [TD−5,TD−1]	-0.3096*** (-6.22)	-0.0300 (-0.50)
Pre-communication Market Return [TD−22,TD−6]	-0.0745** (-2.18)	0.2452*** (5.48)
Pre-communication Firm Return Uncertainty [TD−5,TD−1]	0.0778*** (118.72)	0.1243*** (133.45)
Pre-communication Firm Return Uncertainty [TD−22,TD−6]	0.1183*** (89.36)	0.1593*** (109.45)
Pre-communication Firm Return [TD−5,TD−1]	-0.0599*** (-12.48)	-0.2562*** (-51.13)
Pre-communication Firm Return [TD−22,TD−6]	-0.0704*** (-18.15)	-0.2268*** (-62.68)
Ln(Number of Communication Events +1)	0.0060** (2.51)	0.0061** (2.00)
Ln(Number of Communication Days +1)	-0.0064*** (-7.06)	-0.0074*** (-6.51)
Ln(Number of Meetings + 1)	0.0003 (0.23)	0.0002 (0.14)
Ln(Meeting Length + 1)	0.0006 (0.85)	0.0008 (0.94)
Topic Concentration	-0.0104 (-1.00)	-0.0018 (-0.14)
Topic Concentration^2	0.0144* (1.65)	0.0090 (0.80)
Backward Topic Similarity	-0.0173*** (-2.90)	-0.0266*** (-3.26)
Voter Salience	0.0131 (0.83)	0.0202 (0.98)
Own-party Conflict	0.0003 (0.01)	0.0675 (1.24)
Inter-party Conflict	-0.0244 (-1.31)	-0.0235 (-0.81)

Mapped Survey Share	0.0168 (1.12)	0.0118 (0.59)
Survey Age	0.0000** (2.06)	0.0000 (1.25)
Own-party Conflict Coverage	0.0884** (2.30)	0.0809 (1.40)
Inter-party Conflict Coverage	-0.0874 (-1.06)	-0.0635 (-0.49)
Private Meeting Area Shares	Yes	Yes
President×Firm FE	Yes	Yes
Year-Month FE	Yes	Yes
Weekday FE	Yes	Yes
Disclosure Length FE	Yes	Yes
Obs.	58,766,022	58,766,022
Clusters	Firm, Date	Firm, Date

*Notes. This table reports firm–activity-date regressions of return uncertainty over the five trading days beginning after the last public communication released from t through t+6. Idiosyncratic Volatility is the log root mean square of daily firm excess-return residuals from a rolling Fama–French three-factor model estimated using the prior 252 trading days, with at least 126 observations. Excess Return Uncertainty is the log root mean square of daily firm excess returns standardized using the firm's mean and volatility estimated from the prior 252 trading days, also requiring at least 126 observations. Each meeting date receives equal total regression weight. Both models include the macro pre-event state, public- and private-activity controls, private-meeting shares, political controls, and prior firm return state shown, as well as firm-by-president, year-month, weekday, and disclosure-length fixed effects. The samples contain 22,245 firms and 15,871 meeting dates. Parentheses report two-sided t-statistics based on standard errors two-way clustered by firm and meeting date. ***, **, and * denote significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively.*

Table 11. Topic Similarity, Political Exposure, and Return Uncertainty

Dependent Variables: *Idiosyncratic Volatility*	(1) *Industry-Portfolio Volatility*	(2) *Firm Idiosyncratic Volatility*	(3) *Within-Industry Dispersion*
Topic Similarity × Political Exposure	**-0.0092** (-2.03)**	**-0.0089*** (-3.71)**	**-0.0058* (-1.76)**
Topic Similarity	-0.0205** (-2.38)	-0.0328*** (-4.71)	-0.0227*** (-3.63)
Political Exposure	-0.0399*** (-3.24)	-0.0071** (-2.24)	-0.0251** (-2.04)
Pre-communication Market Uncertainty [TD−5,TD−1]	-0.0174*** (-6.68)	-0.0170*** (-8.30)	-0.0067*** (-3.57)
Pre-communication Market Uncertainty [TD−22,TD−6]	-0.0508*** (-7.48)	-0.0543*** (-10.91)	-0.0130*** (-2.67)
Pre-communication Market Return [TD−5,TD−1]	-0.3084*** (-4.81)	-0.3240*** (-6.13)	-0.2641*** (-5.36)
Pre-communication Market Return [TD−22,TD−6]	-0.0926* (-1.77)	-0.0939*** (-2.61)	-0.1172*** (-2.96)
Pre-communication Firm Return Uncertainty [TD−5,TD−1]		0.0767*** (113.44)	
Pre-communication Firm Return Uncertainty [TD−22,TD−6]		0.1136*** (90.07)	
Pre-communication Firm Return [TD−5,TD−1]		-0.0757*** (-15.53)	
Pre-communication Firm Return [TD−22,TD−6]		-0.0854*** (-22.85)	
Ln(Number of Communication Events +1)	0.0032 (0.98)	0.0055** (2.12)	0.0005 (0.20)
Ln(Number of Communication Days +1)	-0.0056*** (-4.69)	-0.0062*** (-6.16)	-0.0039*** (-4.28)

Ln(Number of Meetings + 1)	0.0015	0.0011	0.0009
	(1.03)	(0.84)	(0.83)
Ln(Meeting Length + 1)	0.0002	0.0005	-0.0000
	(0.24)	(0.65)	(-0.03)
Topic Concentration	-0.0170	-0.0078	-0.0166*
	(-1.40)	(-0.66)	(-1.72)
Topic Concentration^2	0.0276***	0.0166*	0.0211***
	(2.71)	(1.70)	(2.62)
Backward Topic Similarity	-0.0224**	-0.0180***	-0.0183***
	(-2.53)	(-2.61)	(-2.85)
Voter Salience	0.0201	0.0148	0.0081
	(1.04)	(0.83)	(0.54)
Own-party Conflict	0.0076	0.0109	-0.0020
	(0.12)	(0.21)	(-0.04)
Inter-party Conflict	-0.0484*	-0.0310	-0.0391**
	(-1.82)	(-1.36)	(-2.04)
Mapped Survey Share	0.0073	0.0155	0.0336**
	(0.27)	(0.96)	(2.07)
Survey Age	0.0001	0.0001**	0.0000
	(1.49)	(2.13)	(1.13)
Own-party Conflict Coverage	0.1155*	0.1066**	0.0651
	(1.95)	(2.28)	(1.38)
Inter-party Conflict Coverage	-0.1090	-0.1291	-0.1236
	(-0.88)	(-1.13)	(-1.58)
Private Meeting Area Shares	Yes	Yes	Yes
President×Industry FE	Yes	No	Yes
President×Firm FE	No	Yes	No
Year-Month FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Weekday FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Disclosure Length FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Obs.	2,022,408	49,916,901	2,022,356
Clusters	Industry, Date	Firm, Date	Industry, Date

Notes. This table examines whether the association between Topic Similarity and post-communication return uncertainty varies with Political Exposure. Each outcome covers the five trading days beginning after the last public communication released from t through t+6. Following Belo, Gala, and Li (2013), Political Exposure equals the total direct and indirect output required from an industry to satisfy federal, state, and local government final demand, divided by industry output. It is assigned using public-release benchmark vintages and standardized within each July–June formation year: across matched firms in column (2) and across represented industries in columns (1) and (3). The main sample excludes formation years 1992 and 1993, which rely on a proxy for the unavailable 1982 SIC-to-I-O concordance. Industries are defined using three-digit SIC before 2003 and the most detailed matched NAICS prefix from 2003 onward.

Columns (1) and (3) are industry–activity-date regressions, whereas column (2) is a firm–activity-date regression. Industry-Portfolio Volatility is the log root mean square of daily residuals from a Fama–French three-factor model estimated for a June-fixed, equal-weighted industry portfolio. Firm Idiosyncratic Volatility is the corresponding firm-level measure. Within-Industry Dispersion is constructed by calculating the cross-sectional standard deviation of firm-level Fama–French residuals within an industry on each trading day and then taking the log root mean square of these daily standard deviations over the five-day outcome window. Rolling Fama–French models use the preceding 252 trading days, exclude the current day, and require at least 126 observations. Industry-day observations require at least five firms.

*Each activity date receives total regression weight one. Firms receive equal weight within activity date in column (2), and industries receive equal weight within activity date in columns (1) and (3). All regressions include the reported macroeconomic pre-event state, public- and private-activity controls, private-meeting area shares, political controls, and prior return-state controls. Column (2) includes firm-by-President fixed effects, whereas columns (1) and (3) include industry-by-President fixed effects. All columns include last-communication year-month, weekday, and disclosure-length fixed effects. The sample contains 13,502 activity dates; column (2) contains 49,916,901 observations covering 21,567 firms, column (1) contains 2,022,408 observations, and column (3) contains 2,022,356 observations. Both industry specifications cover 461 industries. Parentheses report two-sided t-statistics calculated from standard errors two-way clustered by firm and activity date in column (2) and by industry and activity date in columns (1) and (3). ***, **, and * denote statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively.*

Table 12. Topic Similarity, Private Presidential Access, and Firm Return Uncertainty

Dependent Variable: *Idiosyncratic Volatility*	(1) First Presidential Meeting	(2) All Presidential Meetings
Short-post DDD, [0,6] minus clean pre	**0.3398**** **(2.27)**	**0.2258*** **(1.84)**
Later-post DDD, [7,29] minus clean pre	0.1815* (1.81)	0.1335 (1.64)
Pre-trend: late minus early clean pre	−0.1027 (-0.75)	0.0343 (0.33)
President-Meeting Stack × Firm FE	Yes	Yes
President-Meeting Stack × Date FE	Yes	Yes
Control Group	Not-yet Met	Not-yet Met
Weighting	Episode-balanced	Episode-balanced
Treated Meetings	551	1,001
Stacks	456	806
Obs.	1,040,976	1,628,771
Clusters	Firm, Meeting Date, Last Communication Date	Firm, Meeting Date, Last Communication Date

Notes. This table reports stacked difference-in-differences-in-differences estimates for private-sector presidential meetings involving at least one top-ranked firm representative, defined as a CEO or chief executive, chair, owner, founder, or company president. Column (1) defines treatment as a firm's first meeting with a given president. Column (2) includes all eligible first and repeated meetings between the firm and that president. Treated meetings are required to be separated by more than 60 calendar days from the firm's adjacent meeting with the same president.

Topic Similarity is the seven-day presidential-public-communication similarity measure associated with each communication anchor date. Short Post includes anchor dates from the meeting date through six calendar days afterward, [0,6], including meeting day 0. Later Post includes anchor dates [7,29]. Idiosyncratic Volatility is the log root mean square of daily firm-return residuals over the five trading days beginning on the first trading day after the last public communication in the corresponding communication package. Daily residuals are obtained from a rolling Fama–French three-factor model estimated using the preceding 252 trading days and requiring at least 126 usable observations.

The clean pre-period is defined using the end date of the five-trading-day outcome window and covers calendar days [-45,-14] relative to the meeting. It is divided into early [-45,-30] and late [-29,-14] pre-periods. The reported Short-Post and Later-Post coefficients are linear DDD contrasts: the treated-versus-control Topic Similarity slope in the relevant post period minus its calendar-width-weighted clean-pre average. The pre-trend test compares the late and early clean-pre treated-control similarity slopes.

Control firms are associated with the same president, have no prior meeting with that president as of the focal meeting date, and are confirmed to have their first meeting with that president in the future. Controls cannot be co-treated on the focal date or have their own meeting within the surrounding ±60-day isolation window. Each supported stack-firm cell must have at least two usable communication packages in each of the four timing bins.

All regressions include president-meeting-stack × firm fixed effects and president-meeting-stack × date fixed effects, the complete set of lower-order treatment and timing interactions, and frozen prior firm uncertainty and return-state controls. Because Topic Similarity is common across firms on a given anchor date, its standalone effect is absorbed by the stack × date fixed effects; the table identifies differential changes in the Topic Similarity slope for meeting firms relative to controls.

*Episode-balanced weighting assigns equal total weight to each treated firm-meeting episode and collectively to that episode's eligible donor controls, with weight distributed across timing bins and usable communication packages. "Treated Meetings" counts treated firm-meeting episodes, whereas "Stacks" counts unique president × meeting-date treatment events; multiple treated firms meeting the same president on the same date share one stack. Standard errors are three-way clustered by observed firm, president × meeting date, and last communication date. Parentheses report two-sided t-statistics. ***, **, and * denote statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively.*